

The Hunt
By Chico Montecristi

One

Though she wasn't allowed, Robbin sat with the new nurse, Alma Mae, to discuss the events of Gertrude's death.

Alma had no idea what she was in for. That within the span of *forty-five* minutes she would hear the story of how a local teacher committed suicide, leaving her husband, John, and eight-year-old daughter behind. Some of Robbin's information isn't reliable, for she was not there, but for the most part, she's as close to the truth as anyone else.

"So, where do we begin?" she said. "Mrs. Gertrude Barrow was a teacher at the Little Pines School. Loved and respected by everyone; everywhere she went she would light up the room with her beautiful smile. Growing up, everyone was in awe of her dedication to schooling, her acknowledgement of authority, her leadership amongst us. Her parents, the Sanders, were role model parents. Always went to Sunday mass, members of the parent teacher board, involved in their community, just the best parents that you could imagine. No wonder she turned out so perfect...

"Around town, we got very close to making a schedule so everyone knew when she was available and whose turn it was to have her over. Sunday dinner, birthday parties, and baptisms were booked months in advance. You can imagine how we all felt when we heard the sad news of her death. I heard it before many others. My friend in the department called me later that afternoon... It was quiet that night around my house, but I cried the second my friend hung up the phone. Just couldn't believe she was dead. I thought it was a joke.

“The next day, everyone was talking about nothing else; people started drawing their own conclusions, and suicide was the least discussed. School remained closed until mid-September, the principal thought it was the best thing to do under the circumstances.

“Mrs. B died?” the children would ask in disbelief. “It was horrible. Mostly because we had to see the children’s tears and hear their cries. She was like a mother to them, more than we were at times. Our own children loved her more than us. Their world, their lives, shattered, but her daughter was so strong. Never saw her shed a tear, not even at the funeral. It was strange.

“Gertrude’s parents thought there was foul play and they demanded that the sheriff, hell, the State of Colorado, do something about it. Seeing days had gone by and nobody was arrested, they went straight to the news station in Denver and told them all about it. Became national news overnight, don’t know how you didn’t hear more about it. Next thing you know, we had a Gerald D. Flint coming from New York, ready to defend John’s rights. Something along the lines of “innocent until proven guilty.” Around here, for John, is more like “guilty until proven innocent.” I never liked him after he came back from the war, he had changed, so quiet. I’m sure he did it. He was probably depressed. We had a lot of those guys come by the clinic, like Mrs. Dwight’s ex-husband. He used to beat her every day. Well, he did that before the war too, we all knew.

“People didn’t get to see pictures of the scene in the newspapers, but my friend Bryant gave me a sneak peek. He said he rushed back into town from the nearby golf course and went straight to the scene. The street was lit by cop cars, yellow tape everywhere, like a movie, he said. He couldn’t believe what he heard until he walked in.

The house was intact, no signs of struggle. The sunlight pierced the windows, he could count each particle of dust as though time had slowed down. While the deputies gave him a run-down, he couldn't hear a thing.

“See, around here there haven't been many crimes ever since I can remember. The most that has happened was a brawl over football, not even accidents. A suicide, murder I should say, was way beyond our imagination.

“Making his way to the living room, he saw John holding his daughter, Michelle, tightly, rocking back and forth on the couch. John kept crying and holding her head, patting her hair and shoulder. And, just like me, the sheriff was shocked to see how strong Gertrude's daughter was even though her hands, face and PJs were stained with blood. She simply stared back, letting her father cry against her. The sheriff didn't know what to do or say, so the deputies pointed to the master bedroom where they found the body.

“Gertrude was laying on the bed, under the covers, holding a book. Her blood had dripped for hours by the time the sheriff made it to the room, so he had to tiptoe in, still wearing golf shoes. There was a gun by the bed and Gertrude's hand hung above it. I know you're eating, honey, but I'm just getting to the good part...

“As Sheriff Bryant lifted his eyesight, away from the gun and the puddle of blood, he noticed her brains were scattered across the bed and against the eggshell colored wall. Part of the wound was covered with her soft hair, caving into her skull. Bryant says he almost barfed when he saw her mouth and eyes open, full of flies. It was a hot summer day; I can only imagine the smell. Sheriff Bryant headed towards John to ask him some questions, but John would only rock back and forth, crying.”

“John, we'll need you to give us a statement,” Sheriff Bryant told him.

“But seeing how struck he was, his shaking, how the blood in his hands got stuck to his daughter’s hair, he just couldn’t do it right then and there. The sheriff decided to have him over later that day to describe what happened. And he did. By then the reporters were everywhere and they didn’t leave for weeks. When it was time to head to the Sheriff’s Department, they all ran toward John with their cameras and recorders at arm’s length. And Tom, that gentleman sitting at the end of the counter, he had to put up with it as well. He’s their neighbor you see. He had to testify, and it turns out he was John’s alibi.

“Apparently, Tom gave the same testimony multiple times: *from early in the morning John had been outside working on the front yard. Raking leaves, mowing the lawn, watering plants and filling up his bird seeders. His normal routine. For the fifteen years they have lived next door, John worked on his yard while I read my Sunday paper. Nothing seemed out of place this morning. If anything, I expected to see little Michelle running around the yard helping or playing with the birds. Today I didn’t recall seeing her, but I didn’t think anything of it. After all, she’s only a child. Soon I heard a shot, went to the window and there was John, running towards the house.*”

No matter how many times Sheriff Bryant asked him to go over the story, nothing changed. John appeared to have nothing to do with his wife’s death and the alibi checked out.

Pointing to an older gentleman. “Look at Tom right now, reading his paper.”

Alma looked over.

“Poor Tom, the reporters kept throwing questions at him: ‘Why are you protecting a murderer? Are you in on the murder too?’ No wonder he doesn’t like talking much anymore... They wanted a story no matter whose dignity was on the line.”

Murder sells, suicide doesn't.

"What a shame. Tom has been nothing but a saint, a good man, one of the few left in this town. Reads his paper, goes back to rest, gets another paper, comes back. Every day and don't bother nobody. He got nothing to do with it. It's John that I question. Gertrude? Kill herself? No way!"

"Interesting," Alma chimed in.

"And listen to this! When he showed up to testify, he didn't manage to say much. That Flint, lawyer-man busted in the department and stopped the entire interrogation. Said his client didn't need to answer questions without his legal representation. John didn't even know who he was."

Alma stared at the clock above the window, listening to its ticks.

"Well, I had worked my way into the department with a little help from Sheriff Bryant, so I was able to hear and see a thing or two as this mess unfolded. The interrogation room had a separate screening room, like the ones you see in the movies, it couldn't fit another deputy. Mr. Flint had a whole team of lawyers behind him taking notes and providing him with documents at the snap of a finger. They were preparing for the worst: *The People of Colorado v. John Barrow*."

When the time came for John to give his testimony, everyone in the screening room froze; desperate to look into the mind of a killer, into the mind of a man they thought could kill his loving wife and bathe his daughter in her blood, without remorse.

"It was heartfelt. I could hear him sobbing and screaming the entire time from all the way out in the waiting room."

John could barely make a word without choking up.

“Of course, I got a word or two out of the sheriff afterwards, this was something I couldn’t go to sleep without knowing. Apparently, he asked John to describe the events that took place that Sunday morning, prior and after her presumed suicide. I can only imagine that the deputies got closer to the window, waiting to see what John would confess.”

They did. Feeling a tap on the glass. “Give me a second John, I’ll be right back!” Sheriff Bryant said while stepping outside the interrogation room. “Can you maggots keep it down a bit?! I can hear all of you tapping on the glass! Deputy Stanley, next person to even hint at a word, have ‘em removed.” The room went silent.

“Sorry about that John, ready to begin?”

John responded, “As unfortunate as this may be... Yes, I am.”

“Alright, the floor is yours John. Walk me through this day.” John stared closely at the dark tinted glass, searching for faces.

“I’ll remember this day for the rest of my life and for the wrong reasons. Sundays were always my favorite days. I’d plan all my yard work, gather my tools and materials the night before. By early morning, I had it all done. Then *Trudy* would come out with water, sometimes lemonade, she was so sweet,” he paused. “Loved to see her glancing at the rose bushes, the buttercups and the sunflowers, her favorites. She never stayed out for too long, but for that moment, I felt like the luckiest man on earth cos I had the kindest woman on earth. I know she was very absent, after her brother Michael died, but even then, she found ways to make me feel that I was important to her, that Michelle and I were important to her. I can almost picture her right now wearing her sundress, barefooted, with her hair down.”

“I know it’s hard for you, but c0uld you try to stay within the subject, John?”

Sheriff Bryant asked.

“He murdered that woman!” a deputy whispered behind the glass.

“Please have him removed,” Deputy Stanley requested calmly.

John couldn’t speak. He almost went mute. His thoughts were eating at him.

“John...” Sheriff Bryant insisted

“Yes?”

“Please continue.”

John was under a lot of stress. Hands shaking, sweat rolling down his ear.

John continued, “I want everyone to know what I saw when I saw her. That every time she was near me my throat would close, that when she looked my way I smiled, that there was never one day I wasn’t in love with her, that she’s all I ever wanted.” He stopped to look straight into the glass.

“I did not kill Trudy. She was my everything, my one and only. I would give my life right now if it meant I would see her again. If it meant she would live, and I died. I would put a bullet through my head this second if it would show you the truth, if it would turn back time and brought her back. Brought back Michelle’s mother, my Trudy.”

“Trudy! Trudy! Why did you leave us, why did you leave me?” he yelled.

The sheriff wasn’t impressed and when things settled down, he continued to interrogate him. “Mr. Barrow, who’s gun was found next to your dead wife’s body?”

“It was my gun,” John responded.

“Where was the gun before the incident took place?”

“I kept all my guns in the same case, by the living room.”

“And did this ‘case’ of yours have a key, some sort of security. Say, a lock so that a child the age of Michelle wouldn’t have access to?”

“Of course! It was locked,” he said, “But my keys were in the same spot I had always placed them. Right by the door. Trudy always knew where they were. It wasn’t a secret. I did it mostly because of Michelle... didn’t want her opening the case freely.”

“And why, Mr. Barrow, if I may ask, why would your eight-year-old daughter want to open up a gun case?”

“I’m not sure, I didn’t say she did. I only said that I didn’t want her having access. That’s all.”

“So, you mean to say that somehow, early in the morning, your wife decided to pull *Of Mice and Men* from her library, grab a handgun, go back to her bed, read a couple of pages and then blow her brains out?” Sheriff Bryant’s tone switched from good guy to bad guy at the blink of an eye, but even he knew sensitivity was of the essence. “Let me rephrase the question Mr. Barrow... Does it make sense, for all these events to take place, before your wife ‘supposedly’ committed suicide?”

“No, it doesn’t make sense.”

Another deputy spoke, “I knew it!” another deputy had to leave.

“So, you do agree that things don’t add up, right, Mr. Barrow?”

A sharply dressed man busted through the door. “I’m Gerald D. Flint!” he said, “From now on, I’ll be your attorney Mr. Barrow. You don’t have to say a single word or answer any more questions. The way I see it, for all we know, you are innocent. You’ve done nothing wrong and if there is no evidence to demonstrate otherwise, you are a free man,” was all he said.

Mr. Tom's alibi placed John outside at the time of the shot. Leaving only two people inside the house: Gertrude and her daughter Michelle. The sheriff couldn't pin any evidence to suggest that John was the one who pulled the trigger, but he wasn't going to entertain any other ideas. Since she was waiting outside, Sheriff Bryant decided to call the only other person that was inside the house when everything took place.

This caught everyone by surprise. The deputies rushed behind him. "It's alright boys. John..." Still in shock, he looked up. "Do you mind if I have a word with Michelle?"

Mr. Flint advised him not to. "Absolutely not Mr. Barrow! You are innocent and they have no evidence."

But John obliged. For the deputies, seeing Michelle walk into the interrogation room was unsettling.

"I could see the sheriff scratching his chin while standing by the door, he probably didn't know where to start," Robbin added.

Alma simply nodded and looked around the cafeteria.

Bryant wanted to go about it with as much sensitivity as he possibly could; still exposing enough evidence suggesting Gertrude didn't commit suicide.

He began with something simple: "How are you, Michelle?"

"Good," she responded.

"Excited for the school year?"

"Yes. This year I'm in fifth grade. I got to skip."

"Wonderful! Just wonderful. Did you get your summer reading done?"

"Yes, I did. Read my final page this morning."

“Did you like the book?”

“I liked it very much so.”

John sat by the door, next to Gerald.

“And why is that, Michelle?”

“Because it reminded me of the things my father has taught me.” Sheriff Bryant moved towards the edge of his seat and made sure the recorder was on. The light was red and the magnetic tape was surely spinning.

“Oh, he has taught you things you say. What kind of things, Michelle?” The deputies thought Bryant found his opportunity, but Michelle disappointed.

“Papa has taught me that when things are hurt, we must help them get better,” Michelle responded looking directly into Bryant’s eyes.

Bryant almost began to cry, for even now she showed so much devotion to her father. Finding no way of pinning evidence on John, he stood up and showed Michelle the way out the door.

“She was out almost immediately,” Robbin said.

After a long pause. “That’s as far as I go, unfortunately. Last thing nurse Alma... Make sure to never repeat anything I’ve said. Never!”

“Of course not!” Alma responded.

Time passed by faster than planned. “You sure eat fast nurse Alma. Not even the napkins survived.”

Alma said, “I try to stick to my diet, but I just can’t help it sometimes.”

“Look at me, barely finished my soup,” she paused and looked at Alma, “Sorry, I didn’t mean it like that.”

“No harm done ‘nurse’ Robbin. Mother Berta reminds me every day.”

“We better get back now. I wonder how things are at the corridors. I figure one of us should get back to our patients.”

Alma wiped her mouth.

“All we can do is keep quiet and let the others battle it out.”

“Alright!” Alma said licking her fingers.

“Keep your mouth shut! Most likely Stubby Linda will discipline us by having us reorganize and look over patient charts.”

“I don’t mind...” Alma responded, still savoring her food.

“You say that now, but everyone agrees she’s quite the cunt.”

“You can’t really trust the voices you hear,” Alma said slyly.

Two

Earlier, at the clinic, both corridors were quiet, patients waited, and the moths went about their business, buzzing and slapping the flickering lightbulbs. The wind grazed the windows in circles, carrying one or two dead leaves from the frozen fall. More couldn't be desired from the sleeping bodies that, drugged, managed to get a good afternoon's nap. The men in white coats mopped the floors side to side from opposite ends, with their backs facing each other. Their white shoes gave off a squeaking sound that traveled everywhere, leaving an unexplainable satisfaction in one's ears. Their arms were in tune to one another, and as they squeezed the mops, drops of sweat dripped into the big, yellow buckets that laid beneath. One wrap around their hands freed the dark water within each braid. Slowly, the bleach and water vanished, leaving no streaks behind. The chemical fusion rose quickly and lingered beneath their nails, where we begin to lose contact with our flesh.

The silence ended with one last stroke. From the depths of Corridor B, sprung the loud sound of a door slamming open and the clicking and clacking from someone's feet. It was Dr. Child, walking furiously towards the counter, flapping a yellow file in her stubby hand.

"Dr. Child," the man in the white coat greeted her with his head down, finger on his cap, smiling. She didn't respond and continued walking straight ahead.

Robbin caught wind of the commotion and immediately thought the worst had happened. *What has she done now?* she thought, with Alma in mind. *I told her she's not the talking type. It was a simple in and out job. Drop the file, say hello and leave,* she

continued drawing conclusions in her head. Until her first glimpse of Alma running behind Dr. Child.

Alma had her head down and her bun was coming undone. “Oh boy,” the same man whispered, scratching his head. He looked across the corridor making eye contact with his mate.

Hearing the nurse hustling behind her. “There’s no point in running after me. This doesn’t concern you,” Dr. Child said.

Robbin dropped everything on the table and smiled deliberately.

“Where is he?” Dr. Child asked furiously.

“Who, Dr. Child?” Robbin asked hastily.

Pressing for an answer. “Don’t play coy with me. Where’s Dr. Harris?”

“He was here earlier.”

Sarcastically, “Well I know that. His door is wide open, and he’s nowhere in sight. Anything less obvious you could share?”

“Let’s see. Its half past eleven... he’s probably on his way back from the liquor store,” Robbin responded, looking through the calendar and glancing at the clock behind her.

“So, while he’s out buying more bourbon, I’m stuck here getting more cases? His cases!”

Robbin lowered her gaze, not knowing what else to respond.

“Are you responsible for this, Robbin?” she continued to press.

“My God, no Dr. Child. We’re only following orders.”

“What in God’s name are you talking about? Speak!”

“Earlier today he ordered us to change the caseload, effective immediately.”

“What?!”

“That Mrs. Dwight and her family will now be consulting you,” putting her face down, tomato red.

“You said what?!” Dr. Child asked, stressing the letter *h*, as though she mixed it with ‘who’.

“Indeed. He told us to take the file for your review and that next week she’d be transferred to your schedule.”

“I already know her case,” she was losing her temperament. “For Christ’s sake, everyone I’ve met in this little town knows her case. That woman can’t keep her mouth shut. *Ipsso facto* Robbin.”

Ipsso who? she thought. Not knowing what to say, nurse Robbin responded. “I don’t quite know what to say.”

“How about saying ‘Dr. Harris, is it a good idea to make this change right away without consulting Dr. Child?’ Maybe. Or... ‘*Dr. Harris, why don’t we get Dr. Child to meet with you first, just to make sure she has no other impediments,*’” she provided Robbin with examples while imitating her nasally voice.

Unexpectedly, Alma rushed behind the counter, rubbing shoulders with Robbin.

Alma insisted, “please don’t think I had anything to do with this. If I’ve offended or harmed you in any way, it wasn’t my intention,” apologetically. She meant it. “Robbin, I’d also like to apologize to you if I have done something that brings you embarrassment. I thought I followed every instruction. Did exactly as you told me: keep my mouth shut, give her the file and leave. I promise,” Alma explained with deep sentiment.

They both waited quietly. Not making a single movement.

“He does this all the time: dislikes a patient and immediately sends it my way. I’ve had enough of it! Now he wants to pair me up with the—” she began to whisper, “biggest psychopath of them all?”

Everyone around knew Dr. Child was startled. She was usually a very composed woman, a prude of sorts. Rarely did she speak to anybody but those assigned to her corridor, and even with them she’d only listen, analyze, and share her advice for how to cope, until further consult. Visits always concluded with a typical “We’ll have to look further into this on your next appointment”. Never a personal matter, cold. Yet here she stood, aggravated, exposed to her surroundings, uninhibited by the criticism of her peers.

The phone rang. “Harris & Child Psychiatric Center, nurse Robbin speaking,” she quickly responded. “How may I direct your call?” she asked. “He’s not in at the moment, who am I speaking to?”

Losing her temper, Dr. Child mumbled, “Of course not, he’s on a liquor run!”

On the phone. “Oh, how are you Sheriff Bryant? Almost didn’t recognize your voice,” she said. Her voice sweetened; twirling with the phone line between her fingers. She continued, now with her back towards Alma and Dr. Child. “Sher-iff,” she smiled, “Can’t really talk right now, honey, Dr *You-know-who* is climbing my tree. Think you can call back later?” she asked.

Confused, Dr. Child asked Alma, “What’s she going on about? He’s not here, can’t she take a message?”

Alma moved her eyes side to side, confused.

“Why did you sound so serious? You know I always answer the phone... you thought it was nurse *Bubba Mae*?” Robbin said letting out a giggle. “You almost had me

fooled, thought you really needed to speak to Dr. Harris..." she continued, pulling filing bins to play out the act. "Oh, you *did* need to speak to him... Well, like I said, he's not here right now. Is everything okay?" she asked opening a file with the name *Rita Parker*—not important. "Oh, okay. I'll let him know to call as soon as he returns."

Alma had an idea of who it might've been based on the change of her tone. After all, she had to hear her chatting up a storm every day. But she remained astute and didn't raise any unnecessary attention.

Robbin asked one final question while on the phone, "Hey, sheriff... are you still in the mood to go over that *case* with me later tonight?" She hung up, and with it, too, did her smile.

"Was that another one of his patients? Is this another one of those that he's trying to get rid of and send to me?" Dr. Child asked, steaming out of her ears.

"That was Sheriff Bryant," Robbin answered, glancing at Alma.

Dr. Child was curious. "What did *he* need?"

"I don't really know Dr. Child. He didn't say."

Dr. Child leaned in closer to the counter, so much that she had to tiptoe as her breast laid over the edge. "Can I ask you something?"

"Well, of course."

Dr. Child smiled and angled her chin. "Is there anything you *actually* know? Honestly. That you actually *do* know?" she said leaving Robbin puzzled. Alma raised her eyebrows and lowered her gaze as Dr. Child walked back to corridor B.

As the two began to whisper. "Robbin..."

"Yes?" she responded nervous.

"Do let me know when Harris gets back."

“Of course!” she answered swiftly.

“Oh, and...”

“Yes, Dr. Child?” they both said in unison.

“Do your job and don’t send the new girl down to my office. She’s not my service, *you* are.”

Robbin began mocking her with faces, but Dr. Child turned around, catching her in the act. “Do I make myself clear, ‘nurse’ Robbin?”

All heads turned away. Except for Robbin, who buried her head in the soil, searching for worms, embarrassed.

She bowed. “Of course!”

Alma looked at Robbin, distracted, not knowing what was more interesting: seeing Dr. Child’s true colors or seeing Robbin exposed.

Already past the revolving doors, past the yellow bucket, the mop and its beholder, Stubby Linda said, “I’ll be waiting.”

Alma’s eyes were frozen. “What are you staring at? Back to work new girl. Sign in those patients and reorganize those bins from A through Z, by address and prescription,” Robbin ordered.

“Which bins?” Alma asked confused.

“Figure it out!” her injured superior responded.

Robbin began to fix her already straight hair, sat on a chair and called another patient. “Mister and misses Morris.”

Walking over to Alma, a white coat said, “She’ll get over it. These two have been going at it for years. It’s all a crazy act.”

In her office, Dr. Child wondered why Bryant called. She thought about the Barrow case and whether it was related. She knew Harris and Bryant were childhood friends, but, in her mind, he was not too keen on calling the clinic. Last time she heard of him was five months ago, on the nightly news, sharing some report on arrests made that year. Misdemeanors, local events and the fundraisers held by the department every year, usually a Bar-B-Que or a fishing tournament, followed by a fish fry down by Glen's Creek. But today something felt odd; then again, she rarely left her confinement, he could've called in the past and wasn't privy to it.

She couldn't let it go. *What has he got up his sleeve? What is he trying to dig up from that drunkard?* she thought aloud.

Her desk was covered in files, a picture of an aging man, a pair of round frames and a silver thimble the size of an acorn. From her right coat pocket, she pulled a set of keys and placed them on the space created when thighs join hands. She laid her elbows over the desk and pressed her torso firmly against the darkened edge above the drawer, rubbing her forehead meticulously with the sides of her knuckles.

The skin below her eyes was as thin as a chicken's, staying in place after she rubbed it. "God," she sighed. Hesitating, she opened a drawer with a passkey, moved a few documents and, beneath it, laid a single red folder labeled *Jade Smith*.

Holding it up to the light, she began to open it, as though she regretted it. The phone rang! "Dr. Child," Robbin was on the other line.

"Yes," she responded startled.

"Dr. Harris just walked in."

"Please have him come to my office," she responded while locking the file in the drawer.

“Will do! Will that be all, Dr. Child?”

“Just send him to my office.”

Robbin began to say, “Dr. Child, me and Alma are heading to...” but Dr. Child had hung up.

Grabbing away at her short, messy brown hair. *I can't let this get back to me again*, Dr. Child spoke to herself, still staring at the passkey.

She had developed an unfamiliar relationship with Gertrude prior to her death. They met in Tucson while at a gem festival three years back. Alleys, corners and street ways flooded with tourist from all around the world, gathering after their favorite jadeites and rubies. While searching for turquoise and silver jewelry, Dr. Child and Gertrude crossed paths in front of a small tent ran by a white woman and two Navajo children. May have been Mexicans, it was hard to tell... Both children were silent, staring up with their chins down. Their hair laid flat over their foreheads, one had freckles under his eyes and the other carried a white birthmark below his ear. Not once did they smile, but their teeth poked out. The Arizona heat was enveloping, and the sweat traveled down their bony chests and arms.

Thousands of feet passed by the tent and, through the small doorway, a multitude of patterns and colors worn by the tourists flashed left and right. Some wore shorts with their hairy legs out, orange and brown, others wore light blue jeans and working boots. The pace was slow, steady and uneventful; at times tourists stopped to look at their maps, puzzled, curiously scratching their heads. “Have we gone their yet?” most would ask. But they never knew the answer and continued strolling along with their sweaty feet.

Few walked into the tent, it stood in an awkward spot, near the restrooms. All the stores had a similar set up: white woman accompanied by two young boys that appeared to be Navajo, possibly Mexican. And of all the tents, both Gertrude and Dr. Child, stopped to look at the map and scratch their head in front of this one, by the restrooms.

“You seem just as lost as me,” Dr. Child said to this strange woman looking down on her map.

“Don’t know if I’m lost or simply foolish,” the stranger responded.

“From the looks of it, you’re lost,” Dr. Child said while letting out a laugh.

“Where are you headed?” she asked.

“Well, that’s a good question.”

“So far I figured this is *Campbell* avenue, which means that we’re very close to *Euclid*, where I’m heading,” Dr. Child added, moving closer to see the strange woman’s angle of the map.

“Would you look at that? I’m headed the same direction, to the...”

“JADE STRAVAGANZA!” they yelled at once.

“Small world,” Dr. Child said smiling.

“You betcha,” the stranger responded.

“Hey! That’s my alma mater,” Dr. Child said, pointing at the woman’s shirt.

“My brother went there,” she responded quickly.

“What year?” The question had brought a swift sense of quiet in the middle of thousands. “My apologies, I seem to be asking too many questions,” Dr. Child said while glancing at the stranger’s left hand. “Misses?”

She had a ring on her finger. “Barrow, Gertrude Barrow. A pleasure to meet you.”

“Doc... sorry it’s a habit. *Miss Child, Linda Child.* And the pleasure is all mine.” They shook hands awkwardly. “Again, misses...” she stopped to think.

“Mrs. Barrow,” she reminded her.

“Mrs. Barrow, that’s right! Look at me already forgetting your name. How embarrassing.”

Gertrude said jokingly, “Thought you went to Yale,” they both giggled. “No worries. Try being a teacher on the first day of classes...”

“Oh, you win!”

“And call me Gertrude. Only my students call me Mrs. Barrow, some even call me *Mrs. B.*”

“I almost became a teacher, a professor I should say. I was an English major.”

“So, you were a teacher too?” Gertrude asked with glimmer in her eyes. She felt like smiling, like she found her missing dog. “It’s difficult to come by other teachers around here. At least ones as young as us,” she continued.

Linda laughed. “I seem to have mislead you,” she said. “I was studying English but seeing what being a teacher entailed I figured I might as well work with adults,” she said.

“You should meet my husband, makes my daughter look like a grown woman,” Gertrude responded, joining the laughter.

“Husbands... I see so many of them, so foolish,” Linda said, rolling her eyes.

“I take it you’re a *nurse*?” Gertrude asked.

“Not quite. Turns out I became a doctor. A psychiatrist, to be exact. But don’t go calling me doctor, Linda will do.”

“Oh, look at you, isn’t that just swell. Didn’t think there were many female doctors out there,” she said delighted.

“Not *too* many. At Yale, I had a friend who became a physician, but on the day of graduation her boyfriend proposed to her and now they’re married with kids, live somewhere in Long Island. Montauk, I think. Pretty place.”

There was something about New York that brought life to a conversation, especially with folks who had never set foot on the island.

“So, you’re from New York?” Gertrude asked excited.

“It’s funny,” Linda responded. “The moment I mention that I’m from New York people in Colorado always ask me that same question. Is it a Mid-West thing?”

“Wait, you said *Colorado*?”

“Yes, I moved there last year.”

“Whereabouts?”

“Place called *Plainview*, near Lazy Peaks National Park. You’ve heard of it?”

“Have I heard of it? Am from the other side of Plainview, from The Pines. You’re talking to a Little Pines graduate and now teacher there,” she said proudly. Linda nodded and smiled. “Born and raised in the pines.”

Oddly enough, this may have been the first time Linda looked excited to meet someone proud to be from The Pines, and so they continued chatting and laughing with excitement. Ecstatic, grabbing at each other’s arms in joy.

“Well, this is just fascinating. All this time I’ve been living in that boring little town,” she paused and tapped Gertrude on her shoulder, “and I never bumped into *you*? You’re like a breath of fresh air.”

“By God, I’m just as shocked as you are and, between you and me, the town has gotten better.”

“I’m willing to bet that’s why you’re here today, huh.”

They laughed.

“I’ve never seen you at the market, not even at *Puccia’s Bakery*,” Gertrude mentioned, as though the place was a landmark. “I’m always going there for biscotti and tiramisu.”

“The tiramisu *is* good, I must say.”

“Sure is. Only place in Colorado with a decent Italian bakery,” Gertrude argued.

Dr. Child was certain that she had better Italian in New York, but she played along. “That’s where we get bread and coffee for the office.”

“Oh, by noon time I’ve already gotten home, prepared lunch, I should say warmed up leftovers, he doesn’t notice,” she giggled. “What about mass?”

“What about it?” Linda responded swiftly.

“Never seen you in mass.”

“Oh, I’m not a believer,” she answered with a dull face.

Gertrude asked surprised, “You’re not catholic?”

“No, not at all.”

“Please tell me you’re not an Adventist...”

“Neither. I don’t follow religions. What some may call *atheist*... although at times I feel agnostic.”

Gertrude's face changed colors. The pupils of her blue eyes widened in shock.

"I can almost guess what you're thinking right now, you think I'm a disgrace."

Gertrude smiled. "Not at all, only God can judge."

"Good to know."

"Shall we head to the jade show?" Gertrude asked.

"Let's!"

Making their way through the crowds, sharing details about their life, Linda and Gertrude began what was to become a deep and brief relationship.

Three

Alma Mae was back at her desk, sipping on coffee, business as usual. Incoming patients were seen in the morning, so the waiting room was empty. Afternoons were reserved for record filing, follow up reports, checking future appointments, cleaning patients, serving food and medicine at the cafeteria, organizing charts and calling insurance companies for billing and medication purposes.

Regular sounds echoed through the corridors and the insects fluttered through their short-lived life. Every now and then the doors swung open, bringing in new arrivals of fly and moth that lingered near garbage banks and windows; searching for warm spots like the long, white lightbulbs hanging above. The Pines had little mercy for anything living, and besides the elk and deer, all other animals, quite frankly, appeared dead.

Further down Corridor B, Child and Harris spoke with the door closed, whispering. The sun had moved to the western end, allowing its light to shine through the windows; its rays reflected over the dense library, composed of Hegel, Beauvoir, Foucault, Marcuse, Freud and Nietzsche. Oddly enough, she had quite a collection of Dr Seuss stories. May come handy now that Tim and Lucy were her responsibility. Far out in a corner laid an old rubber tree—not more than six feet tall—and its dry leaves were spread around the base. It was dark hued, rough, elegant; displaying a metal shimmer. In the air, the dust particles danced to Tchaikovsky as they landed on wood, cloth and paper.

“Why is the sheriff calling again?” Dr. Child asked with no hesitation.

“You know Mrs. Dwight?”

“You mean to say the patient you *forced* upon me?”

He nodded and smiled. “That would be Mrs. Dwight.”

“Crazy bitch Dwight,” she interjected.

“Agreed. Well, it turns out she still hasn’t dropped her accusations towards John; she had high regards towards Gertrude. They went to school together and her children, Tim and Lucy, were soon to be in her class.”

Intrigued she said, “Go on.”

“According to her, there’s something ‘off-putting’ about the girl.”

“Michelle?”

Looking up at her. “Yes, Michelle,” he responded.

“Well, what about Michelle?”

“I’m getting there... Mrs. Dwight believes that something was off about the way the girl behaved during the funeral. As you probably know, everyone was there, everyone saw.”

“Saw what?” Harris paused to reignite his dark briar pipe, pressing the lit tabaco with his left thumb.

Fixing her eyes over his pipe. “Must you smoke that in here?”

He cleared his throat and continued. “Dorothy says that Michelle didn’t appear to be acting normal, that her reaction to seeing Gertrude laying in the casket wasn’t sane for a young girl.”

“Depends on what you consider *normal* and *sane*, don’t you think?”

“I must admit, Linda, I’ve seen many cases of children with little to no feelings, as am sure you have, but this was the first time I’d witnessed such coldness. She was only *eight* when it happened, I think.”

“Were you there?”

“Where?”

“The funeral,” Linda said impatiently.

“Of course! Everyone was there.”

“I wasn’t there, that’s why I ask.”

“You’re the exception. You’re new here. Fresh blood.”

Looking out the window. “Thankfully,” she added.

“Around here, if you’re not someone’s friend you’re their cousin. Shit my parents are cousins. Excuse my language...” he laughed. “First cousins, can you believe that?!”

“Yea... Thanks for the info. Do go on,” she said before pinning her finger with her molars.

“I saw Michelle, but she was absent. Her mind separated from herself. Like when we sit and ponder about where we’d rather be, of what we could’ve been instead of being stuck doing something you don’t want to do. Like when we question our existence.”

Child wasn’t too convinced. “We all interpret death differently, same goes with life. Must we all cry to prove that we loved and cared? Must we all be happy to know that we live?”

Harris continued smoking and playing with his beard. A bird flew by the window, casting a shadow over his aging face. “That wasn’t all...” he said, “When I approached her, I felt like I was speaking to myself, like many here do... like some of us currently are.”

He searched for a reflection across the window. “When we gave our condolences, she kept looking at John, who stood by her side. As though she needed his permission for every question,” he faced away from Child. “All we asked was how she was feeling and mentioned that we were deeply saddened by what happened to her mother. She was a loving woman.” This made Linda bite her lower lip and push back on the line where forehead meets hair.

“Again, I don’t think her behavior is odd, she’s a child. What does bitchy Dwight expect?”

“No one said a word to him, no matter how much he cried, no matter how many times he pulled Michelle closer,” Harris went on a tangent.

“Who?”

“John, Mr. Barrow, Gertrude’s widow, Michelle’s dad.”

“Oh!” She thought of Gertrude as he spoke.

“Not to mention, the entire family was split by the casket. On one side stood John and Michelle, while on the other stood the Sanders.”

“The Sanders?”

“Gertrude’s family... Well, minus her brother Michael, he passed away while serving in the war alongside John. Can you imagine your children dying before your eyes, young and in such sad ways?”

“Yeah, *Trudy* never mentioned.”

Surprised. “Huh?” he asked.

“Oh, nothing. I said *you didn’t mention*, her brother, as in before...” her tongue slipped.

Dr. Harris was squinting, confused as to how she knew about Michael and why she called her Trudy. He'd only heard John calling her that, but he continued as though he didn't notice.

"Maybe it didn't seem odd, but, knowing how well natured and caring Gertrude was, we were shocked to see all the children, friends, colleagues, family—the killer himself—and the one fragile girl standing next to her dead mother, simply nodding as the whole town lined up to speak with her. Reminding her of how beautiful of a person Gertrude was and how much she'll be missed."

"She was probably tired. I can understand what she felt: Being put on the stage, asked to behave a certain way, disregarding her true nature, how she truly felt."

Harris said what he had to say. As he stood and walked towards the door, he paused to have a final word. "Most likely this whole thing won't pick up steam, just have your files in order. Bryant is just blowing smoke to get that witch out of his hair."

"Are you going to disregard what I said about Mrs. Dwight?"

"What would that be?"

"I don't want her in my caseload. As a matter of fact, I don't want anyone on my caseload without discussing it first. I've earned my seat at the table."

Harris nodded. "Will do. Oh, and Linda..." she looked up, forming lines across her forehead. "I wouldn't go around calling her *Trudy* if I were you."

Just what I needed, to raise more suspicions, she said to herself.

Immediately, she began erasing her Jade Smith dossier—pictures she had taken with Trudy on trips to the Grand Canyon and Vegas. They had a thing for outdoors and would spend the entire day hiking and sifting through rocks.

Shredded and into the fire her memories went. Until she came across the first picture they took together, bringing back vivid memories of that first time they had met at the gem fest. Gertrude carried a camera when she went on trips. In the picture, Gertrude held up a jade bangle purchased from a Chinaman. Linda bought a matching piece and had the salesman take the picture of the newfound sisters. They were inseparable since that very day. A picture she couldn't get rid of even if she tried. Locking the door, surrounded by books, she slid her back against the wall and began to cry while she looked at Trudy's effortless smile.

With tears running down her eyes. "Why did you leave me, Trudy?" she asked. "Why did you leave me all alone in this town? Things were just like we wanted," she grazed the bridge above her upper lip. "We planned to go to Mexico this very summer. It was all planned out Trudy..."

Letting go of her body, she laid on her side. The rays of the sun illuminated her short, graying hair and what was left of that memory now laid against her chest.

Four

Michelle arrived at her grandparents. I knew because the smell of coffee, syrup and pancakes stuck to the wallpaper. Grandpa Richard read the paper at the end of the dining room table; his wrinkled hands trembled, and his head rocked side to side as he flipped through the pages. A quiet man, moderately dressed, with a scent of oak, olives and bourbon on his breath. Not much of an eater; toast and coffee was more than enough.

“Grandpa!” Michelle shouted.

“You’ll have to get closer to him darling. His hearing has only gotten worse,” Paula said as she prepared more batter. “Could you pass me the blueberries, they’re right there,” pointing to the table.

“Here you go grandma.”

“Remember when you used to make this with me, Mickey? You loved it so much,” Michelle’s face was blank. “You’ve grown up so fast... we barely even see you anymore, and it’s your last year of high school,” Paula continued. “You know we love you right, baby?”

“I know grandma,” she responded.

“Come here, give grandma a hug.” She did, resting her chin above Paula’s head. “Richard, would you look at this! She’s all grown, isn’t she?” he didn’t flinch. Throwing a blueberry at him. “Richard!” she shouted.

“What?!” he responded, sulking. He held the blueberry to his nose, studied its circumference and ate it as he smirked. One would think eating a blueberry consisted in

placing the berry on the tongue, pressing down with the pallet and swallowing its juice, wrapped around the skin, but Richard paused and swooshed purposely.

Paula pointed at Michelle, making light of her tall, slender physique. “She sure don’t get it from you,” he laughed winking at Michelle.

“Grandpa...” she scolded him. “Play nice.”

“Don’t worry, I say worst things to him. Good thing he can’t hear me,” they both laughed.

Early mornings were chilly in the mountains. Her grandparents lived far from town, on the way to Lazy Peaks National Park. The surroundings were brown, orange and green, filled with pine and maple. The breeze dragged leaves like rattlesnakes, squirrels ran across in search of cones and the chipmunks stuffed their faces below the trees.

“Interesting creatures,” Richard commented, referencing an article on the paper. “They spend their lives in fear: In the spring they fear for their offspring, in the summer they fear being the prey of predators, in the fall they fear not having enough food and, during winter, they sleep in fear of losing body fat and heat! What then is the meaning of life if all you do is plan ahead and live in fear?” he asked rhetorically.

“Are you sure you’re reading right, grandpa? Not *all* squirrels hide during the winter. I hunt quite a few every year, good meat if you ask me,” she went on. *He can’t hear me*, Michelle thought.

“There’s no use, Mickey, he can’t hear a thing.”

Noticing the pancakes were almost done, Michelle grabbed plates and set the table. She would sit next to Richard to help him with the food. Parkinson’s had taken over, and when left alone he would splash coffee and food bits all over. He was

hardheaded, meaning his shirt always had coffee and food stains. Paula had assigned a “coffee shirt” for him, although Richard wasn’t aware. The newspaper, on the other hand, was something he could still control, to an extent. Paula thought he did it as a front and would spit out words he caught along the way, next to large pictures. One time he thought the Cubs had won the World Series, but the paper highlighted a Cubs player who *dreamed* of winning the World Series ever since he was a little boy. Not to mention it was winter, February to be exact, and not a soul played baseball.

“How are you feeling, grandma?”

“Me?”

Michelle nodded.

Trying to brush off the subject. “I’m fine, Mickey. One day at a time.”

Lowering her gaze as she poured coffee. “Why do you lie, grandma? It only makes things worst,” Michelle said.

“What would you like me to tell you, Mickey? That I’m happy, that things are just as they used to be?”

“No grandma, but avoiding it isn’t doing you any good either. This, I’ve accepted.”

“But we aren’t all like you, Michelle...”

Not expecting this response from her grandmother. “What’s that supposed to mean?”

“You’re a different breed. Like your father.”

“Please don’t compare me to John.”

“Sorry, it just comes out sometimes. It’s a sensitive matter, you see.”

Now at the table, Michelle poured maple syrup over her stack and took a bite; Richard continued reading the paper and *sipped* on his coffee, spilling mostly.

“Grandpa, here,” wiping his face with a cloth.

He let out a grunt every now and then. “This president...” he commented on a picture.

Looking straight at Michelle, Paula continued, “You know we love you right, baby?”

“You already said so grandma,” she was losing her patience.

“But you *know*, right?” Michelle had her mouth full. “If we could, we would’ve brought you here all along to live with us. We even contemplated moving to town so you could still attend school, we’re too old to homeschool you, you know. We just couldn’t be in town, near that bastard, and everything that reminded us of her. My little Trudy... It was one thing losing Michael in the war, but... seeing her in a casket while that sick sonofabitch!”

Richard glared into Paula’s eyes.

“How are you so sure it was John?” Michelle wondered.

Placing her hand over Michelle’s. “Because we know our little Trudy just as much as we know you, Mickey,” Paula answered. Michelle closed her eyes for a brief second. “She may have been sad about Michael’s death, hell we all were! Still are! But she wouldn’t kill herself. That’s like spitting on her brother’s grave after he sacrificed himself for this country, for *us*!”

Inaudibly, “I see,” Michelle responded.

“But that sick sonofa...”

“Enough!” Richard shouted, pounding his hand on the table. The silverware clinked against the plates and coffee spilled over the white mantle.

They both stared at him confused, surprised. “Haven’t we had enough of this, Paula? Must we carry this burden to our death beds? You think this is what Michael would’ve wanted? Gertrude? We did all we could to bring justice for our li...lit...” he stuttered, “Lit...little girl, but that’s all we could do. The rest is in God’s hands.”

Maybe in someone else’s, Michelle thought aloud.

“What you say?” Richard asked, hearing her murmur between her teeth.

“I thought you said he couldn’t hear a thing, grandma. Seems to me like he’s hearing just fine.”

Shocked. “You’re not the only one he got fooled,” Paula responded, raising her upper lip and lowering her eyebrows.

“You learn to ignore things when nothing is done about it, no matter how many times you try,” Richard explained, looking right back at Paula.

“Oh, the hell with you, Richard! You know just as well as I do that that man is a murderer. They say the war changes you, makes a monster, say you’re never the same.”

“Did it change me?” Richard asked.

“Don’t defend that prick. Especially in front of our grandmother.”

“What makes you think I’m defending him? There’s just nothing to be done about it. Go buy yourself a shotgun,” Richard got rid of all his guns after Gertrude’s death, “See what good it’ll do,” he stopped talking.

Paula was ready to respond. “Grandma just let ‘em read his paper. Finish your pancakes and drink your coffee before it gets cold.”

“Sure, I’ll just eat these warm pancakes while that monster enjoys a nice weekend hunting in the mountains. While my daughter rots below the cold ground, beside her brother.” Their children were buried next to the family campsite, deep in the woods of Lazy Peaks.

Michael Sanders (1942-1972). Loving son, brother and uncle.

Gertrude Sanders (1936-1976). Loving daughter, sister, mother and teacher.

R.I.P.

“I don’t like seeing you this way, grandma, grandpa.”

“See what you caused? God damn it! Can’t you keep your mouth shut woman,” Richard stood, shaking, and left the table.

Paula sat, cleaning the corners of her mouth. “Don’t worry, baby, one day you’ll understand what it’s like to be a mother. Pray you never have to bury your children and feel our suffering. Trust me, we try to move on, but the image of John, the injustice served to our little Trudy, makes us suffer even more.”

#

At a very young age Michelle learned creatures should not suffer, they should be put out of their misery; no matter how cruel it may be, death is the only way to bring them peace. Back then, sitting by the fireplace, Michelle was six, but John believed it was time to take her out for her first hunt, a day she had patiently waited for. She knew her father was a hunter, and every winter she watched him pack his bag with supplies,

grab his rifle and walk into the woods. Year after year, she begged to come along, but she was much too young, and it was much too soon.

On that cold, Colorado night, things went as they had every year: the sound of steel filled the room as John sharpened knives with an old piece of stone he had gotten from his grandfather; letting out a silver lust that bounced off the walls around the fire. Watching from a distance, Michelle was eager to get her hands on one of her own, maybe the fileting knife if luck was on her side, but until then, a wooden stick and a round rock she had gathered from the yard, sufficed the urges building inside. She imitated every hand stroke and, with her thumbs, touched the end of the stick to see if it'd sharpened. As a proud father, John smiled, a moment of joy. Gertrude boiled water above the wooden stove: hot cocoa for the misses and cups of flower, berries and ginger for the grown folk.

The crackling wood brought them together while a tray of oatmeal and macadamia cookies hissed in the oven, toasting below. A small piece of fur laid on John's lap for polishing the steel, and after gliding the sharp edges across the coarse ridges of his fingertips, he sipped on tea.

Michelle would do the same, every year, but this time she was caught off guard.

"Michelle," John called her over.

"Yes, papa?"

"Let me show you something."

Gertrude saw the glimmer in John's eyes; the time had come. She quickly cleared the table and reached for a stained spoon. Michelle was confused. "What's this for?" she asked her mother.

"Papa will tell you after you finish that cookie."

Her eyes moved from her mother and slowly towards John, her head twisted like an owl as she clinched her lips tightly.

Has the moment come? she asked herself.

Soon after, from a duffle bag, John grabbed a piece of deerskin, laid it on the table.

“Join me,” he said, grabbing the spoon. “I’ll show you how to polish your first tool.”

Her eyes were fixed on the knives, but she played it cool. “Really?” Michelle’s attempt to show excitement.

John began giving instructions, “First, we must talk about safety...”

“Just like in school,” Gertrude added.

She couldn’t hear a thing; her mind was blank and flashes of blood dripping from a knife poured on the canvas. “Can you teach me how to gut a deer, papa?”

John and Gertrude were shocked, not knowing what to say.

Michelle added, “I’ve seen you do it before...”

In a shed near the house, John hung his catch to bleed. Though they never explained why, Michelle was always reminded to never go near the shed. A strict rule, one she had broken a few seasons ago. The first time she was only three years old, John wasn’t around, just the deer bleeding into a bucket. Curiosity was killing her. Noticing her father left to town, she decided to go past the door and take a closer look. The deer’s pallid tongue hung out and its eyes were staring directly at Michelle’s. While a swarm of flies flew around, she got up closer and grabbed it by the antlers.

Staring into its dark eyes, “It’s okay,” she whispered, “It’s okay.” She then inspected the kill, looking for the shot, passing her hands lightly over its hair. Saying similar things to the deer. “You were a pretty one, weren’t you?”

Under the dim light, blood continued to drain out the deer’s throat, but she had yet found the wound. What she did find was the faded, metal toolbox full of pliers, knives and empty shells sitting below a wooden counter.

As Michelle riffled through the toolbox, the rattling engine of a truck startled her. “Ouch!” she said, retrieving her thumb from the sharp edge of a knife. John was around the corner, so she ran away sucking on her finger.

After making his way into the house and placing groceries on the kitchen counter. “Is Michelle up yet?” John asked Gertrude.

“Not last time I checked.”

Laying a kiss on Gertrude’s forehead. “She takes up after you, *sleepy head*,” John said.

“Yeah, right.”

“I’m going back to the shed Trudy, make sure to keep an eye on her.”

She nodded. “There’s coffee and toast, but don’t eat too much, I’m preparing lunch.” John reached for a piece of bacon. “That’s not for you. Hands off!”

Michelle listened squatting below the kitchen window, waiting for her father to head back to the shed. As he stepped out, she crawled around the rear corner and hid behind the drying wood, waiting to hear the door close shut. She then made her way towards the woods, taking the long way, and managed to get near the shed without anyone noticing she was awake.

John limped to the shed, staring at the blue jays perched on the pines. He stopped to tighten the contraption holding his right leg straight and noticed one of the belts was starting to rip. Michelle watched him from a distance, until he made it to the shed. It had no windows, and the only crack along the rear was partly covered, but she could still see a glimpse of her father singing and dancing.

“We all live in a yellow submarine, yellow submarine, yellow submarine,” John sung, sharpening his knife, dancing around the deer. All she could see was his legs, parts of his hands, half of the deer and the bucket on the floor. He stopped dancing to lay a sheet of plastic underneath the deer, and standing between its legs, he ran a sharp blade down its white belly. Though the song was still playing, he was quiet, concentrating as fluids dripped over the plastic and the bucket.

Michelle grew anxious, she couldn’t see what was going on above. But soon after, all at once, the stomach came loose and hung like the tire below the willow tree.

Cool! she thought.

After separating them from the carcass, John carefully placed the organs into the bucket; flies indulged in a frenzy as he continued piling them one over the other. Afterwards, he walked towards the water hose, wiped his arms and brought back some water. Michelle, annoyed at not being able to see it all, continued being cautious and listened to every move John made as the radio played. She began to pout, but her patience paid off.

John returned to the toolbox and switched to a heavier knife. The legs were first: slicing through the joints, the hoofs, all removed. With a razor and a plier, he began to pull and slowly detach skin from right to left and from left to right. Flesh and ribcage

exposed, sharp lines along the lean muscles. He slit a circle from the chest and around its neck, pulling the last bits of skin along the spiny bones of its back.

As her father grabbed a saw, an unfathomable expression grew in Michelle's brown eye.

Could it be? she thought, before John began to behead the deer. She felt relieved once the head fell and leaned against its antlers.

Look at your pretty eyes, she whispered.

"Let's save the 'gutting deer' part for later, Michelle," he responded. "For now, make sure you follow what I said about safety."

Snapping out of the memory, "Alright," Michelle responded.

John had placed all the knives in the bag. "Well, that is all for now. Let's go tuck you in, we have a long day ahead of us missy," he said scratching his beard. "Are you ready to go?"

Gertrude stood close with her arms crossed, smiling. As though she was reliving the years that had gone by since her little girl was born.

She's growing up so fast, Gertrude thought.

Wrapping her small arms around his neck tightly. "Ready!" Michelle said, climbing onto his back. Same way they'd done it ever since she could remember.

"Giddy up!" she told her neighing horsey, slightly kicking John's ribs.

John obliged. "Whoa there!"

Michelle's room was quite minimal, just a bed and a bookshelf. Next to her pillow, an old brown camel that she would hug when tucked in.

John sat next to her and gave her a kiss goodnight. "Can we read it again?" she asked before he could leave.

Sighing, "Again?" John responded.

"Pretty please," she insisted with puppy eyes.

"But we've read it four times just this year, Mickey. Aren't you tired of all these *mice* and *men*?"

"From the beginning please," she said, smiling ear to ear.

He was cornered by Gertrude standing by the door. "Girl knows what she wants," Gertrude said. "I'll let you two birds read."

"Night, momma."

"Goodnight," she responded. "I left your clothes in the bathroom for tomorrow."

"Thank you! Goodnight," she said one last time as her mother walked away.

Michelle grabbed her camel and waited patiently, blinking ever so slowly.

"Alright," John said, reaching for the book. "Page one, wherefore art thou?"

She snatched the book from his hands and pointed at page one. "Here you go! Same place, every time. See?"

A few miles south of Soledad, the Salinas River drops in close to the hillside bank and runs deep and green, John began to read. "Say, have we read this book before? Seems a bit familiar, don't it?"

John read close to eight pages and noticed Michelle was falling asleep. He sat the book down, got up and gave her another kiss. *Night Mickey*, he whispered.

As he flicked the light off, she called, "Papa."

He responded with one foot out the door, "Yes?"

"Why doesn't momma ever join us?"

Not knowing what to say. “She’s just a bit tired. That’s all, Mickey.”

“I heard her crying the other night, in the bathroom. Is she sad?”

Her comment caught him off guard. “Nothing to worry about. Get some rest.”

“Night!”

“Sleep well, Mickey.” He stood by the door, pensive, with his head down.

Michelle knew he was there, but she kept quiet and held her plush friend.

The home was small and he quickly made his way to the kitchen. “How are you feeling, Trudy?” he asked as she prepared another cup of tea.

“I’m alright, John, no worries.”

“She said you were crying.”

“Who, mom?”

John took a few steps closer and placed his right hand on her back. “Michelle.”

“What do you mean *Michelle*?” Gertrude asked confused.

“She’s the one who mentioned that you were crying the other night, in the bathroom...” he explained.

“John, I thought she was sleeping.”

“It’s alright, Trudy. You know all I want is for you to get better, to feel better,” he consoled her.

Resting her head on his chest. “I know, John, I know.”

“Am just afraid she’s beginning to understand, and I don’t know what we *should* tell her or *how much* should we tell her.”

“She really loved him, didn’t she?”

“We all did, but those two were inseparable,” he responded. “Remember when...”

“John,” she stopped him.

“What, honey?”

“I don’t want to talk about my brother.”

“Sorry Trudy, got carried away.”

“We should not explain anything else to her. He was sick and he died. That is all she needs to know.”

“Alright, Trudy. Want me to keep you company?”

She held his left hand and said, “Mind if I stay here for a bit longer? I’ll be over soon.”

“Take all the time you need, Trudy. I’ll be here if you need me.”

“John...”

“Yes?”

“I’m doing my best.” Gertrude never made her way to the bedroom. She fell asleep on the couch and around three in the morning John covered her with a quilt.

“Mickey,” he called on his sleeping daughter while rocking her shoulder.

“Mickey,” he continued. “It’s time to go, wake up!”

Turning on the bed. “Morning.”

“Hush! Momma’s still sleeping.”

“Sorry,” she said, rubbing her eyes.

“I’ll be in the shed. I got your toothbrush and breakfast handy. Just come on back and don’t take too long.” John thought he was waking her up, but Michelle never went to sleep. She was dressed and ready to go long before he checked on Gertrude.

“Alright,” she said, yawning. After making her bed, she placed the camel by the pillow, walked over to the bookshelf and wrote in her journal.

December 1st.

Dear diary,

Today I get to kill.

For hours, they walked into the snow-covered hills and passed the juniper trees. Their snowshoes dragged, leaving a trail as they walked deeper and deeper into the white.

Bluebirds chirruped in short flight. “Pretty,” Michelle said with excitement.

“We have to be quiet, Mickey. We’re getting closer to our spot and we don’t want to scare the deer away.”

As the sun rose over the mountains, a small lake glimmered and soon the trees began to disappear; turning into a large meadow. Precisely near this lake, John found an outside corner facing the wind. He placed his bags down, armed a small tent and began to scout the radius with his rifle. Michelle saw and did as father, not to disappoint. Hours went by without seeing deer, the frost dripped off the grass and the morning dew had vanished. So too did the fog and clouds hovering over the lake. Until, at last, on the other side of the lake, a white tail buck approached for water. Aiming his ears towards all sides, studying any movement and, with his beady eyes, looked towards the horizon.

Michelle smiled with excitement and grabbed John’s arm tightly. He put his hand up signaling to wait. Minutes went by and she couldn’t understand. *What are you waiting for? Kill it!* she thought, but John waited.

Then, like a cavalry of Spanish horses, down came a herd of doe and buck; up at the top, stepping slowly, looking over everything, the alpha doe emerged. Her lush,

brown hair bathing in the sun, her eyes fixed towards the woods, the majesty of nature in her step.

John's eyes homed in on one of the younger bucks—a six pointer—closer to the lake. He signaled for her to come closer before taking the shot, and as she moved towards him she stepped on a branch, setting the herd running and skipping back up the hill. He had to take the shot.

“Did you kill it?”

“I didn't get the shot I wanted,” the buck was wounded, “But he's hit. Let's follow the trail.”

They got up the hill as fast as they could, following the markings of blood on the snow. The buck moved steady and they could no longer see him, but the blood spots got bigger along the way. Although John was limping, Michelle could barely keep up and her snowshoes kept getting stuck.

Grabbing her hand, “Come on, Mickey, he's not too far. There's a cave up ahead, that's probably where he's heading.”

The mouth of the cave was wide and low, surrounded by boulders and oak trees, some leaves still green. Critters ran around scavenging for spoils. Nesting birds and shivering squirrels joined in a cry of alarm in the presence of the young hunter. John laid his bag and took off his snowshoes.

“Take your snowshoes off, follow me closely. He can't be too far.”

Water dripped along the cave walls and the sound echoed as it splashed over the limestone. They could now see the blood flowing along the narrow stream, and as they passed the sharp edge of a wall, there it was, on its side, with a large stain above its chest, panting. As they stepped closer, the buck didn't panic, accepted its fate and

looked into Michelle's eyes, just like before, in the shed. Only this time, the buck was still breathing.

She smiled and looked up at her father. "What now?" she asked.

John approached the buck with his rifle and called Michelle over, this would become her first kill.

"He's hurting, Mickey."

"I see."

Without hesitation, John made it clear to Michelle that 'Although it may seem cruel, the best thing to do when a creature is hurting is to put it out of its misery.'"

The buck laid his face against the rock and stared into the stream. John placed the barrel precisely above its heart and told Michelle to pull on the trigger.

"Just put your finger here—pull—and the pain will go away." He placed the rifle in her hand and took a few steps back, letting her take her time.

"It's heavy," she said, bouncing it in her hands.

Michelle could finally act upon her will, her will to kill. And there was no turning back. The buck widened its eyes and waited, staring at her, grazing his hoofs softly against the rocks. John watched, but Michelle couldn't resist the urge. She moved the barrel towards the deer's left eye.

John hesitated. "Mikey! You don't have to..."

It was too late. She had already pulled the trigger, spilling out her desires as well as the brains of the buck.

Five

Not much had changed since she was six. Her desire for blood kept growing; like her lean physique, her chiseled shoulders and deep collarbones.

Michelle walked towards the sink, washed the dishes, put on her jacket and picked up her bag. “Where are you going?” Paula asked worried.

Richard lifted his head and grunted, shaking. “See?”

“Mickey,” Paula continued, “You just got here...”

“You’ll be hearing from me,” Michelle said.

“But... you didn’t finish your blueberry pancakes. Where will you go?”

As Michelle opened the door, the chilly morning breeze swept through the house and unraveled her curly hair. “To hunt,” she responded, closing the door behind her as she headed towards the woods.

Michelle wanted to put an end to the suffering once and for all, and knowing where John may’ve been hunting, she knew there was a long trail up ahead.

Many years had gone by since the last time she walked into these woods on her own, bringing back long forgotten memories. Her initials were carved on the maple trees: *MB*, *MS* and *MBS*. She came across the old tree house—Richard built it more than thirty years ago. The structure was solid with a few broken planks, missing steps and long, black branches pierced through the windows. Though she tried numerous times as a child, she failed to climb it, but now the steps were inches above her head. On her way up, one of the steps came loose leaving her hanging, but she pushed through and made it to the very top.

Spiderwebs and squirrels greeted at the door and a few birds flew away chirping. It was more tree than house on the inside, filled with nests, acorns, and feathers. To Michelle's surprise, pictures of young Gertrude with her friends were still hanging on the walls. In one picture: Trudy wore a Girl Scout uniform while Richard and Paula stood behind her, holding onto her shoulders, laughing. In the other picture: Trudy and friends. Michelle didn't quite recognize them, but she noticed it was a birthday party.

A few books and pencils laid against a dusty shelf. *Grapes of Wrath... What are the odds?* she asked herself. The books were full of markings—Trudy was a stickler for notes and organizers—and on the edges of chapter six she once wrote:

1930s, Great Depression. Pre-war, Post-war, who was the president? WWJD?

Michelle smiled seeing how prolific her mother used to be. *I get it from you it seems*, she said. Pulling on a drawer, she stumbled upon a small, brown book, a diary of sorts.

July 11th, 1946, Trudy dated. I met Penny Pax today. She's fun, likes coloring and loves reading, just like me.

Until that moment Michelle had never felt the urge to cry, but with the sleeves of her jacket she wiped her tears. A hair legged spider crawled on her shoulder as she read the very last entry.

June 8th, 1952. Today I met a nice boy. Tall, brown hair, well mannered, wore heavy boots.

There wasn't much else written, Trudy must've stopped climbing trees. Staring through the crack in the ceiling, Michelle laid on the dusty floor, surrounded by multicolored feathers. The sunlight wrapped around her face and the squirrels jumped from branch to branch. It was time for her to leave and being in her mother's company reminded her even more. But first, she wrote a note on the very last page: *Wish you hadn't met that boy, so that I didn't exist.* This was the very last time anyone would climb this tree.

Now hours into the trail, Michelle began to see the tilting peaks and the glistening lake on the other side of the juniper trees. Something startled her, smoke rose from the camp's chimney, meaning she was right about John's whereabouts. He was staying at the family campsite and had arrived before her—two days to be exact.

On the first night there, he straightened and dusted the place, like Gertrude would've wanted. From the fields, gathered some oats, nuts and flowers; with boiling water prepared oatmeal and tea. He reminisced of the nights he used to sit by the fire with Trudy, how she always burned her fingers turning on the stove. On the second day, John began to write a letter to Trudy, something he wanted to do for a very long time but never managed to finish.

Once, he began to write:

Dearest Gertrude,

I've been writing down my thoughts to reflect on the time since that Sunday morning. Let me begin by saying that I have read most of the books you left behind in

your library, in them I find great solace. I suppose my attempt is to get to know you better through the things you used to read, your interests. You made it look easy... sometimes I barely get past the first chapters, but I push myself and the project has now become a hobby.

Early mornings before I work in the shed, during lunch and at nighttime, while Michelle sleeps, are the best times for me to flip through the pages. Though effaced from the world you once knew, I find great comfort in knowing, somehow, we're still connected. The books are all in alphabetical order, I know how much that irked you, which reminds me... you had your v's followed by u's... Who would've thought? Wish I could have noticed before. Wouldn't that be nice?

Our girl is almost done with high school, principal says she could be valedictorian if she keeps up the good work. She really takes up after you, with all her reading, the studying... Before, I couldn't keep up with the projects she brought home, attempting to impress her peers, now she doesn't need my help. She wants to fit in, you know. But although years have passed, students still see her as my daughter, the daughter of a monster. Mickey pays them no mind. She dragged a six-pointer home the other day! She's gotten stronger, hunting on her own. As for me, I've given up, I guess it lost the appeal.

Surely you want to hear about your parents, they still think I killed you... I'll save you the negatives...

On weekends, Mickey takes the twelve bus to their house, usually Friday's after school. I don't drop her off anymore and they prefer to pick her up at school when she misses the bus. Long drive, but its more "convenient" for them, Paula says. I believe that's how she put it. How can anyone blame them though, you were their only child,

after Michael of course. They felt at a loss, like they'd done something horribly wrong to deserve their fate burying both of their children. As though God himself wished harm upon them. Little do they know... All one can hope for is peace; if this isn't in the cards, someone else's happiness should suffice.

Lately, this has been a theme in my life: searching for peace and happiness. You witnessed who I became after returning from war, how desirous I was for forgiveness. I keep looking back at the time I spent away from you, my inability to erase the image of your brother torn to pieces when I had promised to bring him back alive. You and your parents had warned him of his weakness and so did I, but the courage he showed can only be described as heroic. That's what he is and will always be, a hero. He saved my life and sacrificed his, in exchange of our happiness. "Make her happy" were his last words. I wish one day I could return the favor by doing the same for someone else.

Some days I wonder if I can keep my head high with the calamity of being who I am in this small town, of the image attributed to me, knowing I never placed a hand on you. If anything, all I felt was impotence for not being there to help, for not being aware of the monster I'd created. Now, all that's left is sorrow, an emotional futility that I must live through, for her, for you. This is the price I must pay for all the wrong doings of my youth, my brainwashed decisions in search for meaning, for purpose, when it was always right there in front of me.

Never did I write you a letter letting you know I was fine, that I missed you. Instead, engulfed in my wickedness, devouring the spoils of war, I let Michael write to you with a mention of my being. Such shame it brings me to know that my idea of finding purpose was at the expense of others. That my living meant someone's death. I

do admit, our objective required similar results, with or without me, but the means of getting there isn't deserving of an excuse.

All and all, the true battle is the one I'm currently going through, for you are no longer in the horizon. No matter who wins, you still won't be at the end to greet me in my return. No matter my attempts to escape, I still sleep with the monster.

That day, John wrote as much as he could, until hearing Michelle's footsteps slowly coming his way. He quickly balled up the letter and tossed it in the fire.

"I can't sleep," Michelle said.

"Would you like some hot cocoa?" John asked.

She nodded and sat by the coffee table—same place Gertrude used to sit—rubbing her eyes. The interactions between the two were quiet; John found little to say to entertain her. As though she lived in her own world apart from his. Her talks of the night's kill brought little interest out of John and when he attempted to discuss one of the books he had finished reading, she responded by saying she'd already read it. In a way, these quiet nights by the fire were the only moments keeping them close.

John did, however, make sure Michelle was open about her thoughts, of the urges that built inside her when least expected. With time, he noticed any changes by examining her kill, the precision of her knife. If the cuts were clean and the shot was straight—to the heart—there was not a worry. Practical, efficient. But when John noticed blatant stabbings, unusual dismemberment, a lack of cleanliness, or signs of suffering, he knew she had grown hunger for more.

That very summer, Michelle had done something against all his teachings and all the rules set in place. For starters, she hunted for an entire month before opening day, but breaking the law wasn't the problem, it was *how* she was going about it. Her

neurotic behavior began by killing older does, specifically the matriarchs. She would then leave them out to rot in the hot days of August. The smell of death clung to the air as vultures pierced through their eyes, leaving dark, bloody sockets behind. Soon, bird watchers made reports after bumping into their carcasses, deep in the woods. Nothing was done about it, but as September got closer so did her willingness to pick spots in the open, where anyone could see, and few could ignore. Landowners kept an eye out for hunters, hoping to spot the perpetrator perched on a tree or camping down below.

Somewhere inside, Michelle took this as a sign of a challenge, taking it one step further, begging to be seen. On the last morning of August, a calm day, birds still hadn't fully migrated, and the grass was bright and green. Near a playground not too far from the woods, children rushed into the fields away from their parents. Cheering each other on, running around after footballs and baseballs. Mothers set picnic tables and fathers poured coal into the park grills, though some brought their own. The kids all knew each other from school, parents too, so quickly they gathered and set up games to be played. First up: tag.

"You're it! No, you're it!" the children screamed from all corners of the playground.

About an hour later, couldn't have been more, the parents called everyone in for food: burgers, hot dogs, salad, refreshments, you name it. The children rejoiced and argued about who was faster, how one never got tagged and, of course, how funny it was when the fat kid rolled down the hill. They were eager to get back to play, to enjoy a sunny day. All the moms said the same thing: "In half an hour, after you finish your plates, you can all go back to your games, but for now just eat and rest."

The children nodded. Second plates were passed around as parents puffed on cigarettes. In the air, a mixture of meat, nicotine and coal. Soon one of the girls—missing two of her front teeth, her cheeks full of freckles—began to sing BILLY AND LAURA SITTING ON A TREE, K-I-S-S-I-N-G. It was at this point that parents had enough of their shenanigans, and with cigarettes held between their fingers, sent all the children back to run and play.

The freckled girl announced it was time to play hide and seek. “Yes!” they all shouted.

Things couldn’t get better. Most, already had a spot to hide in: under a picnic table, near the restrooms, inside a car, and under the mats. Pros always opted to go out a bit further, closer to the woods.

Everyone agreed the freckled girl should volunteer first, to which she had little rebuttal.

She began to count. “One Mississippi,” her freckles were dark brown, “two Mississippi,” her hair was long and straight, “three Mississippi,” she peeked through the corner of her left eye, “four Mississippi,” she spotted a friend behind a trunk, “five Mississippi,” she saw her mother fixing her red lipstick, “six Mississippi,” dry sandbur stuck to her white dress, “seven Mississippi,” she pulled some from her hair, “eight Mississippi,” sweat ran down her forehead, “nine Mississippi,” she sneezed, “ten Mississippi... Ready, set, go!”

Immediately, the mats were blown by the breeze and the little white shoes gave the two boys away.

“Uh, uh! Not in my car,” one of the parents shouted. Soon after, walked out three boys, pouting. One of them, selfishly, gave up his friend hiding behind the bathroom.

“Tattle tale!”

Now the freckled girl was down to one.

“You’re not going to find him,” another boy said. “Even if I tell you where he went, you still wouldn’t find him.” And told he did. “He went to the woods.”

“Challenge accepted,” the freckled girl said, smirking. She headed downhill and soon the others followed, leaving the tattle tale and two others behind.

“You’re not going to find him!” he shouted, seeing them disappear into the woods.

Everyone joined the search, but little did they know, he was never in the woods after all... he was hiding in plain sight, under the picnic tables. His friends knew, they were in on it. Although the freckled girl fell for the trick, they still found *something*, but it wasn’t hiding.

The children couldn’t describe what they saw, but the screaming was unbearable. They ran, shouted, and when they reached their parents’ chest and arms, began to sob.

“What’s the matter?!” the parents asked shocked.

Quickly the mothers glared at the laughing boys. “Did you have something to do with this?” each receiving a smack over their head.

“With what?” one responded.

“Don’t be rude,” his father said, laying another smack on the back of his head.

“All we did was trick them. I told them he was down there, but he was always here. Look!”

“I want to go home,” the freckled girl begged.

Seeing their reactions, three of the fathers went down and left the children with their mothers. The tattle tale wanted to join. “You stay right here! And if I find out you had something to do with this, boy I’ll whip you like there’s no tomorrow.”

The boy wasn’t lying, and soon the fathers witnessed it for themselves. About *forty* yards into the woods, in the middle of a glen, laid the butchered body of a doe, on its back, stomach slit wide open. Its legs were pinned down with large rocks, keeping her still while the organs gently swung with the pacific current of the water. The scene had left a stain on everyone’s mind, not because of the smell, the swarming flies or how the vulture picked at the fresh carrion, but because Michelle had gone one step further. She’d left the unborn fawn floating and kicking inside the bile, still attached. To finish her masterpiece, Michelle drew a smile on the doe by slicing pieces off its face.

The parents left quickly to report the scene, asking each other: “Who could do such a thing?”

If only they knew their answer wasn’t too far, for Michelle was hiding a stone’s throw away, smiling like the severed doe. When all had settled and everyone was gone, she rose from the bushes and walked down to her kill, proud as ever.

Her steps grew heavier, her eyes colder; now her boots were wet, sunken in the glen. From her bag, she pulled a knife and began to butcher it to pieces. Each movement of the knife was precise, as though it became an extension of herself, her *true* self. She bagged the meat and moved it to a nearby spot. Organs were tossed by a cave where she

knew the vultures laid eggs. Alas, it was time to decide the fate of the unborn...

showing mercy, she left them to nature, in the bile, below the mouth of the cave.

Hours later, two deputies were dispatched to the park accompanied by the fathers. After guiding the deputies to the scene, both parties were dumbfounded. They had walked to the exact location as before, but nothing was there, not a sign of blood or its carcass, as though it had completely vanished.

“Deputy, it was here, we’re not mistaken,” a father explained.

“You mean to tell us that you dragged us out here for nothing? You’re wasting our time.”

“I swear it was here. Tell him guys.”

“He’s not lying, deputy. We all saw it. We’re not crazy.”

“So how do you explain this? Where’s all the weird stuff you were going on about? I must admit you nearly had me at the edge of my seat earlier, but now...”

“Deputy, why would we lie about this?”

“Let’s kick rock, partner. Nothing to see but a bunch of nancies wasting our time.”

By the time the deputies arrived, Michelle was already back home, and the only remnants of what she had done were the blood stains on her jacket.

Leading John to ask, “What did you hunt for *this* time?”

“Deer,” she said plainly.

“You do know it’s not September yet, right?”

“I know,” she said without remorse.

Pinching his eyebrows. “Then why do it? Have I not taught you better than this?”

“You have father, but it’s something you wouldn’t understand,” Michelle said without explaining.

“Well, are you going to describe how you’re feeling, or should I draw conclusions?”

The tone in his voice was odd for their relationship, as though they were colleagues instead.

Michelle had little interest in explaining herself and began to remove her boots and socks while her father continued talking. Her eyes were empty, as though she wasn’t listening. John began to realize there was little he could do to get her to talk.

Prior to seeing Michelle, John stumbled across some parents at the gas station talking about a macabre scene down by Lincoln’s Glen. From the description, he gathered it was related to Michelle, and seeing how bloody she was only proved his suspicions.

He clapped his hands together and rubbed them like a fly, placing his fingers under his chin.

“Was it you?” John asked.

Michelle stared back. “Was it you who left a doe floating in the glen?”

“Know nothing of it. When did this happen?”

“This morning,” he answered listless.

“Can you describe what happened?” she was intrigued to hear what others were saying only hours after she’d done it.

“I won’t get into details, no need for games.”

“You sure there was a deer after all?” she asked.

John wasn't in the mood for sarcasm. "Some kids found the body and after coming back it was no longer there. It'd disappeared. Like it never happened. There was no carcass, no blood... And yet here you are, blood stains on your jacket, bringing in bags of meat. This is probably your second trip, isn't it? No way you carried all that on your own. Or did you bring Lucy with you?"

"No idea what you're talking about father. This is from hunting, but I don't recall doing anything you speak of," she answered glibly.

John continued. "There's no need to play coy with me, Michelle."

She nodded and smirked. "Aren't you glad that I'm following your footsteps?"

"I don't understand your reference," he responded squinting his eyes.

"Didn't you teach me to clean up after myself?" he searched her eyes. "Do you think I forgot what you told me that day? How you walked me through everything. The way you reminded me to stick to the story..."

"What story?"

She let out a laugh. "Now who's playing coy?" John put his head down, placing it between his hands. "Father, I may've been young, but I remember quite clearly what happened that day and the weeks after. The way you staged everything to make the deputies and the sheriff think it was a suicide."

"Mickey."

"Don't call me Mickey. I'm not a child."

"I did it for your own good. For *our* good."

"How *good* is it now for me? I became the monster people speak of at gas stations, thanks to none other than you. For this you want me to be grateful?" she stood,

exposing her wide shoulders and lean build. “You were thinking of my own good when you had me...”

“Stop!” John screamed.

Her tone grew deeper with resentment. “Why should I stop? What are you so afraid of? It’s me who’s the monster, remember?”

“If you only knew the things I have gone through since that very day,” John ignored Michelle’s questions. “If you only knew how it feels to walk into a room full of people that hate you,” he began to recall a past event. “You probably won’t remember any of this, but I’ll tell you anyways... Remember that clinic I had to go to for three years?” John began. “Well, I had to show up to weekly appointments with Dr. Harris, just to prove I was sane enough to keep you in my custody. The things people called me when they saw me,” John began to reminisce about one of his visits to his psychiatrist.

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“Doctor is there anything I could do to help it?” John asked. “The thought is never ending. I can’t escape it. Every time I think of her I go back to the same morning. Can’t something be done? Any medication you could prescribe. I’m begging here!”

There was never an answer. After two years, Dr. Harris had grown used to ignoring John’s requests, he only sat back allowing John to contemplate within the allotted time.

As Dr. Harris took notes. “Do you wonder what this is like or will you continue to ignore me?”

All he could see were the books aligned across the walls, the dim lamp, the naturalist paintings, a swinging tower clock with the word ‘Germany’ carved on its foot, that odd shaped ashtray and the smoke that rose from an old pipe.

“Your time is up, Mr. Barrow,” John heard as he stared at the clock.

“Wait, that’s it?” John asked confused. “Weren’t you hearing me? These thoughts are making me go crazy! I can barely sleep,” he pleaded.

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“Do you mean the day I shot mother?” Michelle interrupted without remorse. John ignored her question and continued describing the visit.

#

While filling John’s chart. “Have you been taking your medication?” Dr. Harris asked.

“What are you writing?”

Dr. Harris was a pompous man, his arrogance oozed through his tweed blazer, poplin shirt and brown wingtips. “The notes are for me, Mr. Barrow. We’ve gone over this.”

John wasn’t happy with the response. “We’ve also gone over the events that took place, the ones I’m sure you discuss with your nosy nurses.”

Dr. Harris put his pen down by his pant legs. “Do you think I’m deaf? I hear the whispers as I exit your office Dr. Harris, I know what everyone is saying. I know what you’re all thinking.”

“Mr. Barrow, I will not enter a quarrel with you. I will remind you, however, that this is a confidential patient-physician relationship. Rest assured that nothing you say is discussed outside these quarters,” he said, while completing a yellow form.

“Right...”

“Not only would it be unethical of my part, but it would serve as a hindrance to your progress and your court duties. Do understand that.”

John stood, towering over Dr. Harris. “What?” he asked shaken by the statements.

Looking up, “Mr. Barrow,” he tried to interrupt him.

“What in God’s name are you talking about? The case has been closed for over two years now. There was never a case to begin with! I did not kill Trudy, you know this Doc,” John continued, yelling.

Removing his glasses and reaching into his coat pocket. “You are indeed correct, Mr. Barrow. However, it is my professional responsibility to analyze whether you are mentally capable of being Michelle’s parent.”

John laughed. “Mentally capable?”

“Yes! As you know, after you, the closest family members Michelle has are Paula and Richard. In the event that I found you incapable, they would have full custody of your daughter. On the grounds of your sanity, that is. And, legally speaking, you have a few more visits here before you’re completely cleared. Remember that you are here to be evaluated and to assure that you won’t attempt to commit suicide, again. Until then, our offices must communicate with your lawyer and the Sheriff’s Department. Do understand,” he responded.

“Understand what?” John exclaimed.

“My predicament, Mr. Barrow.”

“Oh, go to hell!”

Not long after, two men wearing white coats opened the door and in they went. “Everything alright, Dr. Harris, sir?” one of them asked, holding a ring full of bronze and silver keys. They were sweaty and smelled of bleach.

“We’re alright, boys. Isn’t that right, Mr. Barrow?” he asked rhetorically.

John stared back, grinding his teeth. A scar below his jaw pierced through his gray beard.

Dr. Harris picked up his smoky pipe, took a puff and repeated, “We’re alright, boys. Mr. Barrow was just leaving.”

John threw from his coat feverishly, making every unnecessary sound, took one last look at the notepad, Dr. Harris and the tower clock. Glancing at the men in white coat. “Right, just leaving,” he mused.

They both stood aside and gazed at him, staring at each other briefly, making fists around their keys.

“Oh, Mr. Barrow...” Dr. Harris called, “See you next Tuesday, nine o’clock sharp!”

“We’ll see about that.”

Taking one final puff. “Have a good day now, murderer,” Dr. Harris murmured.

The office was in the middle of a long, white tiled hallway and John would always forget if he should turn left or right for the nearest exit. There were always changes of tables and lamps along the way. The lights were bright and, at times, would flicker. Small insects gathered around the thin bulbs, slapping their wings against the light, making sounds like the sparks shooting from streetlamps. Gray moths hung below, basking in the light, making precise movements with their dusty, eye-patched wings.

John continued talking to Michelle. “I hated the cream-colored hallways, the sounds that carried across, their hollow heels rubbing on the floor, the mops splashing bleach, the wheel squeaking yellow buckets, the clipboards slamming against paper, the pens producing signatures, the keys rattling like hail over metal rooftops, the corridor

doors opening and closing, the banging against beds, the rusty wheelchairs and, of all sounds, the one I hated the most: the voices of mentally deranged patients as they slammed their heads against the padded walls.”

“No, no, no, no, no!” the voices would cycle and repeat. “No, no, no, no, no!” they continued, followed by an unexplained laugh, more like a cackle. This was all white noise, for John could only hear one thing traveling through the halls: *There he is. That’s John Barrow, the murderer!*

“Could you imagine being called a murderer to a crime you didn’t commit?” he asked Michelle. “I would stand while the door closed behind me, fixed my cap and made a right turn past the sign-in station.”

“Shshsh!” everyone hissed to one another while the men in white coats stood nearby.

A fair-skinned boy wearing a thick sweater ran around after his sister, laughing, uninhibited. He stopped to greet me. “Good morning, Mr. Barrow!” Lucy’s brother said to me.

However, before he could respond a voice called out, “Timmy, come!” signaling for the boy to return.

The mother grinned as John looked her way.

“Lucy!” she called her daughter. She had dropped a glove. Seeing how the mother hung on to the children, I felt best to leave it on the counter. The mother continued holding them dearly by their heads and shoulders. So I placed the leather glove on the counter and bid everyone a good day. The men in white coats nodded politely and stood in place with their fists by their sides.

“Thank you, mister,” Lucy said with a full smile.

“Lucy!” the mother silenced her. I stared into Lucy’s eyes and noticed some of her teeth were missing, smiled and walked past the corridor.

#

“I always liked Lucy...” John mentioned.

“A couple of words exchanged between nosy people doesn’t make you a monster,” Michelle said, disregarding what her father had to say.

John walked to the stove and removed the hissing kettle. The window was foggy and drops of water began to run towards the sink. He felt pressured to explain himself, afraid of reigniting the past if he let things get out of hand now that Michelle was growing into a young woman. Quickly, he made up a lie about her grandparents wanting her to stay over during the upcoming weekend while he was gone on a “trip”.

“I’ve been meaning to tell you that I’m going on a hunting trip this weekend and you’ll be staying with your grandparents until I return.”

“Good luck. Hope you catch something big,” she smiled and walked away.

#

Though John wasn’t there to witness, his predictions were right; people did hate him, they did see him as a monster. As he walked out, an airy silence filled the hallway, and everyone waited for John’s final footstep out the door. One of the nurses ran to a nearby room facing the car lot to watch him walk away, past the pines.

“Here are your gloves, ma’am,” a nurse said on her way back from the window.

“Can you believe his audacity to come here and speak freely of what happened, to walk freely amongst us, putting up that act?” Lucy’s mother, Mrs. Dwight, began.

The nurses didn’t respond. “We all know he did it. He’s not foolin’ nobody but himself and that poor little girl. Oh, that poor child—,” she continued.

“You mean *Michelle*?” Lucy interrupted.

Passing her the glove. “Yes,” she responded.

Lucy continued. “She’s in my class. Her name is Michelle Barrow. That’s her father, right?”

“You see, that’s another thing... They’re letting that poor little girl back to school, as though nothing ever happened. He even gets to pick her up after school.”

Everyone listened with their heads down. “Is Sheriff Bryant doing something about this?” she asked, searching takers.

“It’s that lawyer that got him off, I recall,” a white coat responded.

“Yes! Some city folk by the name of Gerald, Gerald D. Flint, if I recall,” suggested the second white coat.

Walking out of his office. “Have you no business to be conducted?” Dr. Harris asked.

The men looked at each other and the woman sitting in the waiting room, grabbed their mops and headed towards Corridor B.

“Dr. Harris, what are your thoughts on the matter? Have you found anything inside that *hell-raiser* head of his?” Mrs. Dwight asked. Her teeth were crooked, her nose drooped over her top lip.

“Mrs. Dwight, I’m sure you understand what you’re asking is, not only, unethical, but incriminatory in nature if I was to answer,” he responded.

After his brief interaction with Mrs. Dwight, he walked over to the counter and gave instructions to the nurses. “Dr. Child will be taking over Mrs. Dwight’s family case from now on.” Both nurses looked at each other confused. “Have her remind Mrs.

Dwight that patient matters are not for public discussion and that she needs to remain in her seat when she's in this area."

"Of course, Dr. Harris. We'll make the changes immediately!"

"Also..."

"Yes, Dr. Harris?" the nurses responded together.

"Schedule John's appointment for Tuesday at nine, yes, nine, nine fifteen, yes, yes."

"Would you like us to contact him about the changes?"

"No, that won't be necessary," he responded.

"Are you arriving late?"

"Not at all. No. I want to have Mrs. Dwight inside a room no later than 10:05, as to not rattle the cage," he explained with a smirk on his face.

They both laughed as though it was an inside joke. Their heads swung uncontrollably. Timmy and Lucy stared amused, laying between their mother's laps.

"What's the doctor laughing at?" Timmy asked.

"Yea, what *are* they laughing at? Lucy insisted.

"They're probably laughing at that man who left your glove."

"But, why?" Timmy asked.

Staring at the nurses. "Because he's a bad man, that's why," Mrs. Dwight answered.

"I don't think so," Lucy said, "He's a good man."

"You get that man out your mouth, right now!"

"He is a good man! I always see him after school," she continued.

“I said stop with that talk right now, Lucy. That man is a murderer, I tell you,” Mrs. Dwight said.

“You’re hurting me,” Lucy whispered.

“You better be quiet now, I said. Don’t you ever say nice things about that man! You see him anywhere and you walk the other way. You hear me?” she repeated.

“But he *is* a good man,” Timmy agreed. “He’s the first person at school every day.”

“Well I’d be darn,” she sighed.

Scratching her head slowly. “It’s true, he’s always there. Why can’t papa be there?” Lucy questioned.

Mrs. Dwight lifted her right hand, aiming at Lucy’s rosy cheeks.

“Mrs. Dwight,” called Dr. Harris.

Pulling her hand back. “Yes, doctor?”

“The ladies will give you some instructions.”

“Are we all set for our next session?”

“The ladies will instruct you,” he insisted.

“Alright,” she grinned. “You two just wait ‘til we get back home, I’ll knock some sense into the both of you,” she whispered as she got up.

Dr. Harris headed out. “Alright ladies,” he said, making circles around his ear with his right index finger.

“Consider it done, Dr. Harris,” one of the nurses responded.

Mrs. Dwight, following his orders, approached the nurses. “Why do we have to service that psychopath, anyways? Can’t he be moved to a different clinic, maybe a hospital out of state?” she asked.

The young nurse intended to respond. "I'll take care of this, Alma Mae. We can't discuss these matters with you, Mrs. Dwight. You'll have to excuse us," she said confidently.

"You talk as though we don't know what happened," Mrs. Dwight responded.

"Like I said..."

"In that case, what are my instructions?"

"Oh, yes! From now on you'll see Dr. Child," the older nurse responded.

Her eyes widened. "What?! I don't want to see her. Don't know *how* she became a doctor. She's a disgrace," she said heated.

"Those were our instructions. If you could please excuse us."

Calling Timmy and Lucy, "Come on children, let's go home. Don't want to be affiliated with *these* people, anyways," insulting the nurses.

"Let's go, Lucy," Timmy insisted. "Let's go!"

Lucy swerved between couches and tables, going straight to her mother. "Can I have my other glove?"

"No! And throw that one away."

The nurses found her actions amusing. "That lady is a mess. I'm almost glad her ex-husband beat her. Have you seen her talking to the wall?" the older nurse said.

"Aw, don't say that," Alma responded.

"You don't know half of what went on in that family."

"So, what did he do?"

"Her husband?"

Alma corrected her. "No, not the Dwights. The man that was here earlier, Mr. Barrow. Why does he come see Dr. Harris?" she asked.

“Well, for starters, he was *assigned* to us; initially it was Dr. Child’s case, but she begged Sheriff Bryant and Dr. Harris to have her removed from the case. She had some conflict.”

“A conflict of interest?” Alma asked.

“Something like that. And since it was out of her hands, she had to write a letter to District Attorney Mathers and the Sheriff’s Department explaining the reasons why,” she stopped to tap nurse Alma in her arm, “More like fear of working and being in the same room with John.

Alma was intrigued. “Go on.”

“Well Dr. Child reacted *funny* when the case was assigned to us, she wasn’t happy with the circumstances.”

“How so?” Alma asked.

“It happened before you started working with us,” she said as she looked around, poking her head over the counter. “This does not leave this table, no matter who asks you, no matter how eager you are to let old Berta know. Understand?”

“My mother and I don’t discuss much about work, I’d never tell her. Anyways, I understand. Promise!”

“Well, alright. Wait, how much do you know about the death of his wife?” she asked.

“All I know is that someone got murdered, died, committed suicide, something of that nature,” Alma responded.

“That’s it?”

“That’s what I heard on the radio when I worked in Austin, I’m guessing it must’ve been important,” she added.

“Look, how about we wait ‘til lunch and I’ll tell you all about it. As long as you don’t mind the details while we’re eating.”

“I should be okay,” Alma responded.

They both looked over the counter. “Here you go,” said a silver haired lady, passing over a small plastic cup.

“We will be with you shortly, ma’am,” the old nurse said with a condescending tone.

“She’s such a cute old lady,” Alma mentioned.

“She’s nuts! Go and run this chart to Dr. Child. Let her know *mister*, I mean, Dr. Harris has requested the case transferred immediately.

“Alright.”

“Oh! Don’t linger in her office too long, she doesn’t like that.

“Alright,” Alma Mae said.

“Alma,” she was called back again.

“Yes?”

“The chart...” they both laughed.

Heading towards the office, Alma bumped into the men in white coats. They both smiled. “Careful now, don’t want to be in that office *too* long.”

“Oh, how bad could it be, boys?” she asked, giggling.

All the rooms were labeled *101* through *120*, followed by the letter *B*, and the doors had a small window in the middle. Patients wore similar uniforms, not purple and not red, but right in between. Supposedly, the color raised the spirits for the patients that grew tired of the white clinic, the medicine, the routine food (toast with butter, a strip of ham and an overcooked egg early in the morning). For dinner, patients had a choice of

mashed potatoes, vegetables and chicken or a hardy soup. During supper there wasn't much of a choice; it was always leftover soup.

Towards the end of the corridor the doors changed, the window glass replaced by a judas hole. Alma was curious and unlatched the peephole slowly, careful not to draw attention, letting her see what hid behind: Everything patted snow white, lights bright as the moon, and a small barred window welcomed the sun. She saw a patient kneeling under its warm rays, trying to reach his beard and tangled hair with his shoulders. Alma couldn't quite make his face for his back was towards her, but he continued reaching with his shoulders while bowing to the sun.

As she observed, one of the white coats dropped his mop, startling her. Quickly, she shut the peephole with a loud clank.

The patient was alarmed. "No, no, no, no, no," he began to scream. "No, no, no..." as though he woke from a dream.

Hearing the noise, a white coat said, "No worries, he does that all the time. Don't pay him any mind... We'll take care of it."

Relieved. "Thank you," she said, as he searched through his keys. "By the way..." she continued.

"Yes?" the white coat responded. His mate joined before walking into the patted room.

"Who is this 'Dr. Child's I keep hearing about?"

"Oh! Someone who used to work here long ago. Again, don't pay them any mind," he said, closing the door behind. "Alright, *Sharpshooter*, must we put you down?"

Six

1930s, Great Depression. Pre-war, Post-war, who was the president? WWJD?

Though John and Michelle were the only ones who knew exactly what happened, across The Pines people had developed stories of their own. The public was unsettled with the decision made by the Sheriff's Department after the death of Gertrude Barrow, lack of evidence or not. And although the investigation was closed within weeks, there was one person who wasn't afraid of voicing her opinions. After her visit, Mrs. Dwight dragged her children across the street and headed towards town. Lucy's hands quickly grew numb from the cold, they soon burned, but she never said a word. She stared at Tim on the way to the car, staying clear of her delirious mother. Mrs. Dwight covered her hair with a silk scarf decorated with tulips and polka dots, she tied it below her chin and completed her veil with a pair of large sunglasses, covering most of her round face.

"Move faster, runt!" she hissed at Lucy, yanking on her arm.

"But, it's slippery," she responded, mispronouncing her consonants.

She stopped to yell at her. "Should I drag you down this road?! God knows I will. And don't think I forgot about your little scene back there. You'll get what's coming to you."

After hearing these words little Lucy felt the urge to cry, but she knew she couldn't. Not in public.

"I'll help her," Tim said, hopping over to Lucy's side. "Don't push her buttons Luce. You know it'll only get worse," he whispered.

"Keep her on her toes, Timmy. I don't want us spotted 'round here."

Gently pulling on his sister's arm. "Yes," he responded.

The walk to the car was three kilometers, could have been more. Occasionally a bus passed by with the number *twelve* and the words *Lazy Peaks* mounted on a white board. There were few stops along the way: near the clinic, in front of the timber mill, The Pines, and Lazy Peaks the final stop. The Pines was a quiet town: local grocer, mom and pop diner, a drug-store by the name of the same town, Al's Meats & More, the Town-Hall, Sheriff's Department, the Prudent Barber—ages three and up—across the street from the fly-fishing store, owned by the only Barber in town and ran by him as well. So too was the travel agency with large maps of Italy covering its sign: Genaro's Little Italy. A busy part of town, especially in the early hours of the day, just before noon, when most closed shop for lunch. Donna Puccia's Bakery would ring its bell all morning as costumers came and went through the door with brown bags filled with wheat loafs, cream-filled desserts, rolls and assortments of cakes.

Not too far down the road was Little Pines Middle School and the library. Both small, brick-layered, connected to one another with a large chimney as their point of intersection. The smoke mixed until late hours, and combined with Donna Puccia's the town was scented with pine, oak, vanilla, tree nuts, molasses, cherry and tobacco. The "Little Pines scent", as some would call it.

"Hurry, runt, it's almost noon."

"There's our car!" Timmy screamed.

"Shotgun!" the children yelled, running towards the front seat.

Mrs. Dwight tried holding on to Lucy, but there was no use, she was already gone. "Lucy!"

Tim slipped, giving Lucy the chance she'd been waiting for, but at the door, smiling gaily, her mother whispered in her ear: "Don't even think about it."

She grabbed Lucy by her arm, yanked her from the door and waited for Tim to make his way, as victor. "Now you know that little girls keep their mouths shut."

The car was parked in front of the diner and as she got ready to drive, she saw a familiar face sitting at a window booth. One she had many aching questions for, Sheriff Bryant.

"Well look who it is. If it isn't mister Sheriff 'No Good' Bryant," she smirked, pausing to touch up her lips and powder her nose. "How about we get some burgers today?"

The children didn't know what to do or how to respond. They thought she was playing tricks, but it wasn't so, she meant it. She looked directly into Tim's eyes and then back at the diner's large bay window.

"What would you like, Timmy?"

He couldn't control his excitement. "Really?" Bursting with joy thinking of the thick grease poured on the sesame seeded buns. "But, didn't you say that—"

"But nothing, Timmy. Today may just be your lucky day," she said.

Looking at his frowning sister. "Did you hear, Luce?" he asked.

"Boy, really?" Lucy responded. Her face reddened and the shivers disappeared. She looked up to her mother and asked, "Is it true?"

Maybe Lucy made it too easy, but Mrs. Dwight's smile grew wider as she laid her hands over Timmy's shoulders.

"I never said anything about *you*. But at least now you get shotgun."

Tim stared at his younger sister as she lowered her face towards the salt patched cement below her feet. He glanced up at his mother pleading for mercy.

“Let’s go, Timmy,” turning him towards the diner. “Would you like some fries and a strawberry—Lucy’s favorite—milkshake, too?”

Tim loved his sister very much and he genuinely wanted to help, but days like these didn’t come often. Beggars can’t be choosers.

Looking back at Lucy one last time. “Yes,” he answered.

Denied she was, pushed further down the spiral like the ‘runt’ her mother always called her. With her head barely poking through the car window, she could see the bright, red sign—Dean’s Diner—with a big burger beside it.

“Welcome to Dean’s Diner. Table for two?” a skinny, dark haired waitress greeted them as they walked through the door. Her legs were pale and skinny, exposed above her knees. Her black apron, tied at the back in the shape of a bow. Mrs. Dwight removed her sunglasses and began to untie the knot below her chin, revealing deep craters besides her droopy nose. A pink moon.

“But it’s you, Dorothy! Almost didn’t recognize you,” the waiter realized.

Mrs. Dwight nodded.

“Boy has Timmy gotten big! Last time you were here was God knows when. How old is he now?” she asked.

Without answering her questions. “We won’t need a table, Barb,” she responded. Taking a glance around the room, she searched for a familiar face. The diner was spacious and stretched across the grill, surrounded by stools of red and black pigments, mounted on aluminum stilts. Newspaper were passed around and others called out sections they were trying to read.

“Anyone done with the sports section?” a fat man yelled.

“Almost done, Bill,” an old man responded from the other end of the grill.

“I think I had next. Don’t be messin’ with me, now. Ain’t got all day,” a raspy voice joined the calling.

“I said am almost done,” he insisted.

“More coffee, Tom?” the waitress asked.

Without taking his eyes off the newspaper. “I’m alright for now, thanks,” he responded.

On the cover of the paper a large picture of a young man running across a football field, crossing through, what appeared to be, the opposing team. He had a bison on his jersey and helmet with the number *forty-nine* inscribed below.

“That’s Jake’s kid. Rumor has it the Broncos are scouting him before the end of fall ball, some scout by the name of *Noah Fischer*. Fisher has been after his father for weeks now. Even asked my boy if he knew where he lived,” the man next to Tom whispered, spilling his crumbs all over his jean jacket.

Tom wasn’t into small talk, usually kept to himself and read for hours. He enjoyed being left alone and everyone knew, they just wanted to get a word out of him for years with little luck to be had.

“Is that so,” Tom responded.

“I ain’t lying, Tom. I mean what I say,” the man continued. This time he would only get a nod and the turn of a page.

“Listen here. I know Jake’s son and he ain’t said a lick about no scout coming by to see him,” another man chimed in. Did these men have anything better to do?

“I said, I ain’t lying!”

“Nobody said you were lying. I said you got the wrong kid. You’re talking about the boy that lives down by the creek. Old Timer’s grandson Willy. *He’s* the one the Broncos are coming over to see. Jake’s kid ain’t going to no Broncos. He going to—” he was interrupted.

An argument broke out. “Well, here you go again. You just think you always know it all. Don’t you?”

Seeing the commotion. “Now I know why you haven’t been coming around here much, Dorothy. Don’t blame you. These guys go on and on about college this and football that. Some God knows which team from Florida and the almighty Cowboys,” Barb spoke to Mrs. Dwight, who lacked interest. “I love those Cowboys, but boy am I getting sick and tired of hearing them yap about it all day and night. It’s like there’s nothing better to talk about. Am I right?”

“Barb.”

“Yes, Dorothy?”

“Could you be a doll and ask Sheriff Bryant J. W. if I could have a word with him? It’ll only be a moment?”

“Well of course, Dorothy. Would you like for me to get you started with some coffee while I am down there?”

Removing her long coat and gloves. “I’m alright for now, Barb,” she responded. Her hips wobbled as she placed the coat on the hanger.

“Alright, Dorothy. I’ll be right back.”

The smell of meat, eggs and butter consumed the room. At the very end of the grill, under a slow drip filter, laid two piping hot pots of coffee. Each table had its own

bottle of ketchup, tabasco, salt and pepper. No mantle laid over them, but they all had silverware, an empty cup and a white, Marlboro ashtray.

On her way to Sheriff Bryant, Barbara straightened the forks and knives, closed the menus and laid bottles of ketchup upside down. Her shirt exposed her back and her skirt sat above her knees. Sheriff Bryant faced away from the door and continued to read the economy page closely. Might have been the local news, it was hard to see the front page. There was always a report of current developments throughout the country, the nation's current affairs, overseas and, occasionally, the paper shed light on small towns, farming, crop production and yield. Sheriff Bryant was from a farmer family himself, brother to a well-known corn farmer down in Arkansas by the name of Bill Bryant, of Bryant & Bryant Farms. National suppliers of corncobs, corn grain, flour, syrup and oil. Naturally, Sheriff Bryant knew a thing or two about farming even though he wasn't a farmer anymore.

"Did you see this, Tom?" Sheriff Bryant asked across the diner, neither one turning.

"If you are referring to the draught in Missouri, then yes, I have," Tom responded.

"Ain't that a thing," he mused.

"Would you like more coffee, Sheriff Bryant?"

"Yes, that'd be good, sugar," he responded. "You've forgotten all about me," he flirted.

"Oh, stop it, sheriff," Barb said, playing with the hair along the ears that never seems to grow or stay still.

Holding the knot on the back of her black apron. “You wouldn’t leave me all alone *every* day without some sugar, now would you?” he continued.

“Aren’t you just the slickest around all the pines, sheriff,” inching a little closer.

Mrs. Dwight wouldn’t take an eye off Barbara. “Oh Barb,” she called. She trained her facial muscles for any circumstance, still, with just the right teeth to lip ratio. Her chiseled jaw formed the smile patients get after receiving a new set of dentures. Lifeless.

She turned and twisted her neck like an owl, smiling. “Barb,” she continued. Barbara was focused on her dance with the sheriff, all smiles and giggles, now almost laying on the sheriff’s lap and chest.

“Oh, that’s right! She wanted to tell you something, but I forgot.”

“And who may that be?” he asked. Now both of their backs were towards everyone.

“One second, Dorothy,” she responded half asleep. She leaned against the booth, bending her right knee.

Sliding his left hand up her skirt. “What you think that lady wants from me?” he asked.

“Oh, sheriff,” she moaned. “What if Bob turns around?”

“That man hasn’t turned around from that newspaper in *fifteen* years kiddo. I think you weren’t born yet,” his breath grew heavier. He was down to his knuckles, holding his cigarette tightly in his lips.

Her eyes were closing. “Barbara D, should I come there myself?” Mrs. Dwight interrupted.

Barb stood and straightened her apron, picked up her small pad and with a flick of her fingers, snapped her panties back in place.

“Not again!” the sheriff exclaimed, wiping his fingers with his left trouser leg.

“What’s wrong? She just wants to have a word with you.”

“Did she say what for?”

“She didn’t mention. She rarely comes around after the whole husband thing.”

“That lady never quits with her questions. Tell her I’m only waiting on some fries, then I’ll find a way to get out of here. Maybe you can call me over to the counter, act like my food was ready?”

“I thought her case was closed... wasn’t it?” she asked.

“Who said anything about her? Her husband’s long gone. I think she’s crazier than him, anyways,” he responded.

“Then how do you suppose I get rid of her?”

“No way of getting rid of her, she’d only follow me to my car. That nosy bitch gives me heartburn every time I run into her.”

“She’s here, no way around that. Let’s get you some coffee and I’ll send her over for some teatime. How does that sound?” she smiled.

“How about I take you on back, by the ally, and slam you on that wall, grease you up *real* good. Been a while.”

“Silly Billy. She won’t fall for any of your tricks. Everyone knows you don’t move from here, all day long you just sit in that booth.”

“God!”

Barbara walked towards Mrs. Dwight, still smiling. She glanced at coffee mugs and filled as she went.

“Bob?”

“Sure, why not. Won’t hurt anyone,” he said.

The more she poured coffee the more impatient Mrs. Dwight grew. Her heels began to click against the greasy floor.

“Momma,” Timmy called, pulling on her coat.

“Not now, Timmy.”

“Can we get a milkshake for Lucy?”

Rolling her eyes. “We’ll see.”

“May I go to the restroom?”

“Can’t you wait!” her impatience was noticeable across the lines of her forehead.

“I have to. I know where it is.”

Mr. Tom turned his head and looked at Tim.

“Run, but don’t talk to Bob or Bill, got it?”

“Alright!” Timmy flew between tables and stools, flashed through Barbara, Bob and Bill.

“Timmy!” Bob and Bill yelled gaily.

“Oh no, not today,” Timmy responded. He knew just where to go, every table and every turn.

“Timmy!” the cook yelled, joining in on the hollering. “That a boy!”

Mrs. Dwight was tired of the waiting game and made her way to Sheriff Bryant, unannounced. The old heads turned, waiting to see where she would end up.

“What you say to Timmy now, Bob?” Bill asked.

“I ain’t say shit to him, I swear,” he stood and took off his hat. “Mrs. Dwight, I ain’t say nothing to him. Just hollered that’s all.”

She kept walking. “How many wives have to get shot by their husbands to get your attention, Sheriff Bryant?”

He reached to shake her hand, but she just sat, without asking. “Mrs. Dwight, pleasure seeing you around here,” he started. She glared, pursing her lips. “He’s grown to be a fine boy, hasn’t he, Mrs. Dwight?”

“Sheriff, do try to take me seriously, I have the least of time to waste.”

“How would you ever think such a thing? My job is to serve the kind folk on this side of the peaks. What do I owe the pleasure?” he continued.

“I wouldn’t call it a *pleasure*, sheriff.”

“Has your husband harmed you again?” he smirked.

She was not afraid of who could hear her. “No, not at all. We both know why I’m here. Say, when do you think you’ll find time to put that monster behind bars after all, huh?”

“Sheriff Bryant, how are you sir?” Tim greeted.

“Hey there, Timmy boy! Get over here and show me those guns.”

“I’m eight now, sheriff, I’m not a kid no more. I reckon I can take you and show you who is boss around here. I can take all the bad guys out myself,” Timmy boasted.

Seeing Timmy climbing on the sheriff’s legs. “What have I told you about interrupting me when I’m speaking with adults?”

“Sorry, I was just—”

“Oh, no harm done. He’s a good kid, Dorothy. He’s just a boy.”

“Don’t teach my boy bad manners; certainly don’t teach me how to raise him, been doing it on my own for quite some time now.”

“I was just saying, Dorothy. Let ‘em be a boy, that’s all.”

“Come over here, Timmy,” Mr. Tom called on him. “Let me show you this game called *sud-a-co*. Supposed to be the best thing since penicillin.”

Tim looked towards his mother. She nodded. “Don’t be climbing on him though.”

“I won’t. Promise!”

“Really, Dorothy.”

“That’s *Misses* Dwight, thank you.”

“How may I help you, *Mrs.* Dwight?” he obliged.

“I already said what I was here for, sheriff. Do you take your job seriously or does Barb take too much of your time?”

“Which question you want me to answer first?”

“Do you find this amusing, sheriff? Think murder should be taken lightly?”

“Seems you have come to talk about the Barrows, haven’t you?”

“Damn skippy!” The old heads were eavesdropping. “Are you going to let that city boy come here and let that murderer walk on our streets, raise that innocent little girl, live freely, like nothing ever happened, huh?”

“Dorothy—”

“I said *Misses* Dwight, damn it! Did I stutter?” she said, almost spitting on him.

“The investigation was closed for over two years. There is no evidence pointing to her being murdered. It’s a done deal. Everything points to a suicide. Did you read the

papers? The facts were laid out clearly. John had nothing to do with it. That bitch was just as depressed as you are,” Bill and Bob laughed.

“Something amusing, Bob?” she asked.

Clearing his throat. “No ma’am, not at all.”

“So why don’t you sit there and shoot the shit with your old pal Billy and let me and Sheriff ‘No Good’ Bryant have a talk,” she scolded him.

The sheriff continued. “Mrs. Dwight, at first... even after John was cleared, a part of me, and, quite frankly, all of us in the department, didn’t think she had it in her,” his voice softened along the circumference of his coffee cup. “For God’s sake, she taught most of my boys. Yours too, right Bill?”

“Mm-hmm.”

“Bob, yours?”

“And my grandsons,” Bob added.

“See D, we all knew Mrs. Barrow pretty well, most of us had her at our homes at some point, for a birthday, a graduation, a communion. Hell, we even had her family over for Christmas at my house. My brother was her classmate. I take back what I said earlier about her being a bitch... she was a sweet woman. All my kids loved her, so you can understand the shock we received when we found out she blew her brains out. And, if I may remind you, I was at the scene, before all the reporters came hopping all around their house like bunnies, so I know what I saw. I remember it like if it was yesterday—”

“It wasn’t that long ago, sheriff,” she interrupted.

“Let me continue. I remember it like it was yesterday, that Sunday morning. I was out with my father-in-law that weekend, golfing at Old Timer’s Hideaway. The old

man and me where shooting the shit, you know. I don't remember if we were in the eleventh hole or the thirteenth."

"Why is this story relevant?"

"Let me finish."

"Order up!" Dean yelled.

"Will it be to go today, sheriff?" Barb asked.

"Barbara, honey. In the last three or so years, when have you seen Sheriff Bryant leave this booth with food in his hands?

She began to answer, "Well—"

Dean interjected holding a slice of American cheese. "Honey, she doesn't *actually* want you to answer. What you said they call that, Tom? Re-what?"

"Rhetorical," Tom answered.

"Dean."

"Yes, Dorothy?"

"Is she one of those *Mongolic* children they talk about in the family magazines?"

"Don't mind her, Dorothy, she's still getting her regulars down."

"I bet she is. Saw her getting this one down *real* good earlier."

"She tends to be a little slow from time to time, Dorothy. She gets it from her mother, I guess," Dean paused. "Take this tabasco down to the sheriff." Not knowing what to do, Barb stood in place. "Ain't got all day now. Don't you worry about Dorothy, she's as cool as a cucumber."

Indignantly, "Just bring me my food," the sheriff responded, sighing.

"That Dorothy sure has a lip on her," Bob whispered at Bill.

"You mind your business, Bob," the sheriff shot Bob down.

Bill kept laughing. “What are they all laughing at, Mr. Tom?” Timmy wondered.

Getting a pen out his pocket. “Don’t know and I sure don’t care. Say, why don’t we do this sud-a-co, what you say, Timmy?”

“Well, how do we do it, Mr. Tom? Never played it before.”

Tom had broad shoulders and a hunched back. His silver hair was well cropped on the sides and even sitting down he was taller than Barb.

“Good question,” Tom pondered. “Say we read these instructions here.”

Back at the booth. “Sit back down, Mrs. Dwight. Let me finish my story. So here we were, out there, eleventh hole, or was it the thirteenth? Let’s say the twelfth, who cares right.”

“I sure don’t,” she sneered.

“Well I do know that I was winning, that I *do* know. So, we were there at Old Timer’s hideaway, smoking these Dominicans, shooting the shit. Then I see a caddy running over, Ned’s boy, mind you he ain’t the fastest of all, little sonofabitch can eat a horse all on his own and still say he’s hungry,” he recounted, gushing. Mrs. Dwight wasn’t quite amused, but he continued. “So, there he was, dry heaving, catching his breath, crimson red, and he goes:

—She... She... sheriff—

“What, what is it? Spill it out boy,” I told him.

—They, they—

“Well I’d be darn if I could hear a word out of you.”

—They said they, they need you down at the station. A call came in about fifteen minutes ago. They, they say it’s urgent! —

“So of course, Dorothy, I went ahead and asked him: *Is it urgent enough for me to stop whipping this old timer’s ass?*”

“Here’s your steak hon-, sheriff.”

“She’s grown quite the liking to you hasn’t she,” Mrs. Dwight tittered. Barbara turned and began to walk away. “Barb...”

“Yes, Mrs. Dwight?”

“I’m ready to order now.”

“Oh, that’s right! Thought you weren’t ordering.”

“Is that so... Burger for the boy, Dean knows how he likes it. Chocolate shake and a strawberry to go. Large onion rings and a baker’s dozen of old chicks.”

“Coming right up!”

“Oh, that’s right. Timmy!” she called on him.

“Yes?” he responded, newspaper in his hand.

“Did you say you wanted fries with your burger?”

“Yes. You said I could, right?”

“Of course. I take care of *my* children. That I do. Not like some *other* folks, apparently,” looking towards Barb.

“Will you want a side of fries then, Mrs. Dwight?”

“That’ll do.”

Barb glowered back. “Coming right up, D.”

“Oh, and Barb...” she was enjoying this moment.

With the last bit of patience Barb responded. “Yes, ma’am?”

“Try to make it back in time. Don’t catch yourself at another booth down there.”

Barbara knew the best thing to do was walk away, as fast as she could. Same as the others, so they turned back towards the grill, letting things return to business as usual.

“I don’t quite get how to play this, Mr. Tom. See I’m not that good at math. Most of the time my teacher says I should think about a better way to add numbers other than using my fingers. The other day they had me add twenty-one and thirty-two, but, you see, my small fingers only go as far as ten.”

Tom smiled. “Well would you look at that. This game only needs *nine* numbers.”

“Which ones, Mr. Tom?” he asked, hopping insatiably.

“Ho there, horsey!”

“Timmy, don’t make me run over there!”

“According to the instructions the Japs gave us, we only need the numbers one through nine. How does that sound, Timmy boy? Think you could swing it with *eight* fingers?” he teased.

Shocked. “Eight fingers? What are you talking about, mister? I have ten fingers. Look! Wait a minute. Have I been counting wrong this whole time?” he started counting, “One, two, three...”

“He’s only teasing you, Timmy, don’t let ‘em fool ya,” Barbara chimed in. “What you doing to that poor little boy, Tom, don’t you see he has to deal with Miss *You Know Who*.”

“I reckon you’re not, too, good at listening are you?” he rebuked.

“What do you mean, Tom?” she asked curiously.

“Do you recall a certain person telling you to keep your lips to yourself?” Tom asked.

“She can’t stop me from talking to you, though, Tom. You’re the life and joy of this diner.”

“You see, I much prefer you did,” he insisted, this time taking his eyes off Tim.

“You much preferred what, Tom?” she responded licking her lips, perversely.

Looking directly into her eyes through the top edge of his glasses. “Keep your lips to yourself.”

Everyone heard and felt the ease of his response, his swift intention, but nobody moved. Not an inch. Just the sound of the grill hissing under meat patties.

“What were we saying earlier about that boy getting scouted?” Bob tried to get things back in order.

“You mean old timer’s boy Willy?” Bill responded.

“I thought I told you that’s not his son...”

Meanwhile, the Sheriff barely began to pepper his steak with salt and tabasco sauce. “Would you be so kind as to pass me the napkins from the table behind you, Dorothy?”

“Well of course, J.W., no problem at all,” she turned. “Here you go.”

“Thank you kindly.”

“Maybe you can wipe that silly smirk off your face, too. Don’t think for a second that you’re fooling anyone, sheriff. A city slicker got from under you and showed you a thing or two about playing with the law. You may be able to fool that mourning family, but you sure ain’t foolin’ me. I have known you since you were a little boy. I know how lazy and incompetent you are. What is it going to take for you to put

that man where he belongs? Does he have to go and kill another person? Maybe kill his daughter, Michelle, next.”

“Mrs. Dwight, I’ll remind you of who you’re talking to right now,” he cautioned, chewing.

“Oh, I know who you are. The same one who shook my pig, husband’s hand after you arrived at my house five years ago, knowing he had just broken my nose.”

“Don’t be raising no accusations against me, God damn it! I’m still the sheriff on this side of Lazy Peaks,” raising his voice. “You’ll respect and abide my authority, is that clear?” he snapped, while chunks of potatoes rolled from his mustache and back onto his plate.

“No need to get alarmed, sheriff. I see the law from a different perspective. You see, you guys let my husband,” she paused, “ex-husband, walk too. I know how simple it is to push paper under the rug.”

Almost choking on his food, he responded, “This is absurd! What in the hell do you mean we just ‘push paper under the rug’? He didn’t kill her. It was a suicide. We’ve looked at the evidence time and time again and it always points to the same conclusion, she put a bullet through her head. We tried to make something stick, but there was no evidence suggesting he did it. That’s how the law works. Innocent until proven guilty.”

“Do you really believe that yourself, sheriff?” she insisted. “In the time you’ve spent knowing her as a teacher, as a child, all the functions we have spent together: birthdays, Christmas caroling, church Sundays. Must I go on?”

“I preferred you didn’t,” he responded cutting his steak.

“Could you remind me again of what your responsibilities as a sheriff are, exactly?”

“Well, I’d be darn. Are you going to instruct me on how to do my job? Why didn’t you do your job with your husband six years ago? Maybe he wouldn’t have beaten you up so bad, wouldn’t he,” he asked, raising his left eyebrow.

“Funny how you admit to it after the fact,” she smirked.

“Come on D, everyone knew your husband was beating you. You were lucky he ain’t kill you, I reckon.”

“You’ve always been the clown all along, maybe for once you could act like the law,” she began to gather her purse, sunglasses and scarf.

His fingers were greasy from the fries and the tabasco sauce. With the same dirty napkin, he wiped his lips and his fingertips.

“See, Dorothy, around here there’s always going to be two things for certain,” he began, poking his yellow teeth with a wooden pick.

“Is that so?”

“I’m the law around here—”

She interrupted. “Until the lawyers from out of town show up, yes, you are.”

He smiled, stood up and tightened his belt. “That’s precisely why we all know about the second,” he continued.

“Let me guess, that you’ve never done your job?”

Grabbing onto his white, fur hat. “Not quite.” He looked around the room making sure he had the opportunity to say what he had to say. An almost endless pause.

“What would it be then?” Dorothy insisted.

He got closer, holding her tightly by the wrist, looking right into her left iris and down to her scarred lip.

“That your nose don’t know the difference between a wall and a sneeze.”

She was left speechless, incapable of finding a rebuttal. Like when someone hangs up the telephone.

Letting go of her arm. “Goodbye, Mrs. Dwight,” patted Bill & Bob’s shoulders and started towards the door, not giving her a chance to respond.

Barbara ran towards him, eagerly. “Is that all, sheriff? Don’t you want to finish our *conversation*?”

“Maybe tomorrow, honey, I lost my appetite,” he lamented, tucking in his hat. “Later, Tom.”

Voices muted as the ringing of the doorbell faded. There was a sense of urgency in Barbara’s eye. Turning to Mrs. Dwight, smiling, vengeful.

“Are you also leaving, D?”

“Dean,” ignoring her question, “can you make that to go please.”

“Sure, Dorothy, coming right up,” he quickly hid behind the grill, letting the steam camouflage his expressions. He began to whistle an Elvis tune, off beat.

“Are we leaving?” Timmy asked, looking at his mother.

“We’ll have to finish this another time, Timmy boy,” he answered for her, with regret.

Dorothy began to speak to herself. “Look at him just waltzing around like a hen. No wonder this town is going to hell, that’s how it all starts. First, we let people kill freely and then you’ll see the niggers move in, soon after. What happened to this town?” raising her voice. “We used to be a respectable town, they used to write about us in the paper, we were a swell town, and Puccia won Best Pie of the West ten years ago. Look at us now, just a bunch of lawless perverts going on about sports. Take a good look at your sheriff while that sick sonofabitch prepares to kill again, while he prances around,

you just wait and see,” the men scratched their heads. “Then we will be the judge of what happens to Sheriff ‘No Good’ Bryant. What is it he does anyway, besides sipping on coffee and flirting with girls over steak?” they kept their heads down. “While you all watch him and greet him day in, day out,” she paused and stared at the bay window, “Come, Timmy,” grabbing him by the shoulders. “Go on and get us our coats,” he went. “Nothing to say, huh. You’re all just like him, you all forgot about poor Gertrude. Don’t your grandsons and children bring her up during thanksgiving dinner? They all loved her plays. Remember when your daughter cried on stage, Bill?” walking towards him, he nodded. “Bob, how about you, wasn’t Pam good friends with her?” another nod. She looked towards Tom, hesitant, pondering. She pounced. “And you—”

Not letting her finish. “Don’t drag me into your little theater act, sister. That won’t play well with me,” Tom cautioned.

“But you’re their closest neighbor, you saw her live there for fifteen years. With that scumbag. You didn’t see a single red flag?” she continued interrogating him.

“Are you a lawyer? I reckon you’re not. I said what I had to say to the Sheriff’s Department and that’s that.”

“Nothing?” she insisted. “You grew up in my dad’s time. You’re one of the few men left in this town. It’s your responsibility to seek justice for that little girl, her mother, the Sanders. It’s everyone’s responsibility!”

“I’ll say it again,” he said, placing his newspaper down, the page with the Sudoku half filled with pen marks and numbers. “I heard a shot, looked out the window as fast as I could and there he was, in the distance, running towards his house. I reckon instead of worrying about some other family and someone else’s ‘little girl’, you should be worried about your own. She’s been sitting in that car all along, hasn’t she?” Dorothy

appeared embarrassed. “I reckon she’s getting an earful from Bryant right now,” he pointed towards the bay window with his eyes and there he was, talking to Lucy. “Gentlemen,” he saluted, placing a brown hat over his wrinkled forehead. “If you’d all excuse me.”

“Let me get your paper, Tom!” Bob yelled, eagerly. He didn’t respond, just left it on the table.

Bill got to it first.

“Hey, I asked for that!”

“Snooze you lose.”

Seven

Early morning, as he promised, John set out for his hunting trip, to his favorite spot in all of Colorado. He went to the family cabin, to be with Gertrude. Same cabin Michelle stared at from the top of the mountain.

“Together at last, father,” she whispered.

On her way down, the hike quickly became a run. Her stride faster, weaving pines and boulders. Fawn ran startled and the crossbills sung to the tune of her steps. Hearing the water’s wrath, she knew the cleft was up ahead. Small rocks ran underneath her boots, the colors of leaves drastically changed, and the air warmer. Large birds hovered above, woodpeckers searched through the sap, and perched ahead, a horned owl turned its head. Closer to the bottom animals were larger. Few could harm her if caught in the way of a den; much too early for the gray wolf, but not for the black bear.

Along the rocky slopes, nannies and billies displayed horns and plush, white coats, staring down at the commotion. The smooth velvet of the mules poked through needles as they stumped against the ground. A grazing bull grunted and charged towards Michelle—almost taking her out—but the pine was plenty and she easily made it through. Nothing surprised her, she had grown amongst the wild things and knew where they hid.

The major threats and hurdles were behind her and no bears were in sight, so she stopped at the edge of the lake and took a quick gulp. Trout swam freely, polka-dotting the calm surface. She was now at the family campsite, and across the lake sat the cabin.

As she drank, the door opened and there he was, standing, holding on to a fishing rod, waiving as the breeze filled up his chest. *The chickens have come home to roost*, John thought aloud, taking off his hat.

Mother and uncle rested at the end of the lake and so Michelle decided to pay them an overdue visit. Their tombs had been cleaned and besides Gertrude's laid a bundle of sunflowers and buttercups. Seeing her intentions, John walked back inside and glanced through the kitchen window. No better moment than this for him to boil water, grab cups and fill them with dried flowers, berries and ginger.

She knelt. "Look what the wind has dragged down the mountain, momma," she said soothingly, letting go of her bag.

The sun was right above them, shining on the lake, and as the wind picked up, so did the glimmer. Her hair, golden as honey, curled around leaves and twigs, some marmots watched from a distance, letting their yellow bellies soak in the sun. Michelle looked around and indulged in the memories that took place on this very land: The smell of the grass, the dried bark, the heat emitting from the rocks, the softness of the pebbles she once skipped across the lake, the faint taste of wild meat, her first sight of a wolf and the blood of its prey. Memories that were all too vivid.

Facing Michael's tomb. "Uncle Mike, long time no see. Heard plenty of stories about your death, but I figured out which one was true," she giggled. "Glad we got to play good guys vs. bad guys." She paused and crawled closer to her mother's grave. "Mother, by now you know I've killed you. Unfortunately, I find no pain in what I say. Though the memory still haunts me, I've remained that monster 'til this very day."

She waved goodbye as John prepared the tea, same way Gertrude had done on those cold Colorado nights as they sat by the fire. “Hey,” he said softly as Michelle made her entrance.

“Father.”

“Made us some grown-folk tea, seeing you’re not a kid anymore.”

“What brings you here?” she asked.

“I could ask you the same...”

“Came here to speak to mother and uncle, had to get something off my chest.”

“Is that so?” she nodded. “How do you feel?”

“Much better, after confessing to mother.”

“What did you confess?”

“That I was the one who killed her, as you know...”

“Michelle,” he started, pouring more bourbon into his tea.

“John.” He was surprised to hear his name. Reminded him of the way Gertrude would call him. She continued, “I know what you did, I wasn’t that young. I remember the day vividly, father.”

“I remember you were sleeping while I worked outside.” These were the exact words he said when he was brought in for questioning at the Sheriff’s Department when asked about Michelle’s whereabouts.

“Do you remember wiping off my fingerprints from that revolver?” John didn’t want to hear. “Do you remember how I smiled with the gun in my hand?”

“Please stop,” John pleaded.

“Suppose you forgot how I picked at the hole at the side of her head...”

“Please stop, please,” he begged.

“How I ran my fingers along the blood as it trickled onto the floor.” He covered his ears with his hands and began to rock, as he did that day. “The way you told me to stick to the story so that the ‘boogie man’ wouldn’t take me away.”

John kept rocking and began to repeat: “No, no, no, no, no.”

“You loved Mickey and so you lied for her. So that she could have a life of her own, at the cost of yours. If they had found a way to prove you were guilty, you would’ve accepted, for Mickey’s sake. Wouldn’t you?”

“No, no, no, no, no!” he bellowed. “Stop, please stop!”

“Father...” she leaned closer. “Father,” holding his hand.

“Yes, Mickey?”

“Since that day, Mickey died. What you see now is who I really am. A monster.”

Grabbing a picture from the coffee table. “You’re not a monster, you’re my Mickey. You’ll always be my Mickey, see?” pointing at the photograph.

She wanted to console him. “I was hunting you down to let you know that it’s not your fault. You didn’t make me a monster, I was born this way and that’s how I will go.”

His jaw came loose. “What do you mean *you’ll go*?”

“Not once have I said this,” she paused to grab his hand. “Thank you.”

“For what?” he began to panic, pulling her hand towards him.

“Thank you for trying to make me normal, now I must go.”

John ran towards the bookshelf and grabbed the same revolver he hid years ago. Only one bullet remained in the chamber.

Placing it against his head. “Put me out of my suffering before you go.” Seeing the darkness ahead, she was left with no choice but to play along.

Manipulating him. “Father, I meant that, now, I’m going back to grandma and grandpa’s house. Nothing else. Promise! *Mickey* wouldn’t lie to you, papa.”

He was quickly convinced. “You’re right,” he said, removing the gun from his head.

“Hand that over,” Michelle requested, taking the gun from him. She checked the chamber. “How about we sit outside and finish this tea next to momma and uncle?” her voice was angelic.

“Do you forgive me, Mickey?”

“You’ve done nothing wrong, so there’s nothing to forgive.” John smiled as she led him out the door. Sweat ran down his chest and forehead.

“I got your cup, Mickey, let’s go see about momma.”

“Alright! Hey, could you pour a little of that *brown stuff* in my cup?” she asked, cracking a smile.

“Oh, no! Momma wouldn’t like that. You’re still little Mickey in these eyes.”

John knelt at the edge of the lake and splashed water on his face as Michelle stood behind him, waiting. In silence, she closed her eyes and reminisced about her first hunt, her first kill, how it made her feel to take that shot.

Oh Mickey, we are so glad to have you back...

The trout splashed, elk ran, and the birds flew at once, shaking the branches of all the trees. Everything went white. Like the snow over the peaks, like the owls perched on the pine, like the white coats standing by the door.

Don’t pay him any mind, for his was lost long ago...

Once again, Michelle pulled the trigger.